חָכְמָה מִחוּץ לַבַּיִת

Wisdom Outside the House

Keturah, the Bnei Kedem and Yishmael

A shiur for Parshas Chayei Sarah from the writings of Rav Tzadok HaKohen of Lublin and the Izhbitz–Radzin school

Chayei Sarah ends with two families leaving Avraham's house: the sons of Keturah, sent east with "gifts," and Yishmael, whose twelve sons settle "before all his brothers." Rav Tzadok and the Izhbitzer read both endings as a question about wisdom that lives outside the house of Avraham: what Avraham gave it, why he sent it away, and how it comes back. The shiur follows that question from a puzzling midrash to its answer.

How to read it. The main text is interlinear, phrase by phrase: each short Hebrew phrase is followed by its English in bold. For Pri Tzaddik, Mei HaShiloach, Beis Yaakov, Kometz HaMinchah and Divrei Soferim, the English follows Akiva Publishing's translations, cut to match each phrase. The pesukim, the Gemara and Pri Tzaddik, Mishpatim 4 are newly translated, with abbreviations written out. The footnotes bring supporting sources from across the Kisvei Rav Tzadok library, and from other seforim that say the same things: kabbalah (the Zohar, Zohar Chadash, Recanati and the Shelah), machshavah (the Maharal, Ramban, Malbim and Taz), chassidus (Me'or Einayim, Kedushas Levi, Tanya, Arvei Nachal and Shem MiShmuel) and mussar (Avos and Mesillas Yesharim). Each source heading links to the passage in the reader, and each footnote source links to Sefaria. Part X follows the same pattern into later generations; its notes on the people give their dates and link to a biography.

The shiur at a glance

I. "Your latter end will greatly increase" — Why does the Midrash call Yitzchak the small beginning and Keturah's sons the great increase? (Pri Tzaddik 6:1)

II. The gifts: a Name for use in impurity — Avraham gave his sons a holy Name that works even in impurity; for the Beis Yaakov, the receiver decides what it becomes. (Sanhedrin 91a; Pri Tzaddik 6:3; Beis Yaakov 36)

III. Eastward — The sparks of the Oral Torah were exiled among the Bnei Kedem; Shlomo's wisdom grew by drawing them out. (Pri Tzaddik 6:4–6)

IV. "Sons of Keturah" — Holding Torah without grasping its depth. (Zevachim 62b; Pri Tzaddik 6:2, 6:7)

V. Yishmael: the wisdom of nature — The names of his sons, and what "shifchas Sarah" left in him. (Mei HaShiloach I:5; Beis Yaakov 37)

VI. Wisdom needs attachment — "Before all his brothers he fell." (Beis Yaakov 40)

VII. The husk before the fruit — Twelve princes before twelve tribes; the chaff carries the grain; the gate is Yaakov. (Beis Yaakov 39; Kometz HaMinchah 2:59; Beis Yaakov, Toldos 7)

VIII. Yishmael's teshuvah — In Avraham's merit, from Avraham's root, because desire can be refined. (Bava Basra 16b; Pri Tzaddik 8; Divrei Soferim 38; Pri Tzaddik, Mishpatim 4)

IX. The answer — Light that comes out of darkness: the "great increase" of the end. (Pri Tzaddik 6:8)

X. Out of the East, in later generations — Bavel, Aram, Charan, Persia and the lands of Yishmael: the light drawn out of their darkness, and hidden Jewish souls in Yishmael's house today. (Pesachim 87b; Sanhedrin 24a; Poked Akarim 6; Pri Tzaddik, Tazria 8; Resisei Layla 46; Pri Tzaddik, Yisro 1)

I. "Your Latter End Will Greatly Increase"

The pasuk

בְּרֵאשִׁית כה, א · Bereishis 25:1

וַיֹּסֶף אַבְרָהָם **Avraham again** וַיִּקַּח אִשָּׁה **took a wife,** וּשְׁמָהּ קְטוּרָה. **and her name was Keturah.**[1]

A midrash that seems upside down

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ו׳ · Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:1

בְּמִדְרַשׁ תַּנְחוּמָא (חַיֵּי שָׂרָה ח): **In Midrash Tanchuma (Chayei Sarah 8):** "וַיֹּסֶף אַבְרָהָם **"And Avraham again** וַיִּקַּח אִשָּׁה **took a wife,** – (בְּרֵאשִׁית כה, א) "וּשְׁמָהּ קְטוּרָה **and her name was Keturah" (Bereishis 25:1) –** זֶה שֶׁאָמַר הַכָּתוּב: **this is what the pasuk says:** "וְהָיָה רֵאשִׁיתְךָ מִצְעָר **"Though your beginning was small,** וְאַחֲרִיתְךָ יִשְׂגֶּה מְאֹד" (אִיּוֹב ח, ז) וְכוּלֵי; **your latter end will greatly increase" (Iyov 8:7), and so on.** לְמֵאָה שָׁנָה **At a hundred years** הוֹלִיד בֵּן אֶחָד (יִצְחָק), **he fathered one son (Yitzchak);** הֲוֵי אוֹמֵר: **so you must say:** – "וְהָיָה רֵאשִׁיתְךָ מִצְעָר" **"though your beginning was small" –** זֶה אַבְרָהָם; **this is Avraham;** – "וְאַחֲרִיתְךָ יִשְׂגֶּה מְאֹד" **"your latter end will greatly increase" –** שֶׁנָּשָׂא אִשָּׁה **for he married a wife** וְהוֹלִיד עִמָּהּ **and fathered with her** כַּמָּה בָּנִים בָּאַחֲרוֹנָה. **several sons at the end.**[2] וְיִפָּלֵא הַדָּבָר, **Now this is astounding:** שֶׁדָּרַשׁ "רֵאשִׁיתְךָ מִצְעָר" **he expounded "your beginning was small"** עַל יִצְחָק אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם **of Yitzchak our father, peace be upon him,** שֶׁיָּצָא מִמֶּנּוּ **from whom came forth** כָּל אוּמָּה יִשְׂרְאֵלִית, **the whole nation of Israel,** וְעַל בְּנֵי קְטוּרָה **and of the sons of Keturah,** שֶׁהֵם עוֹבְדֵי עֲבוֹדָה זָרָה **who were idol worshippers,** דָּרַשׁ "וְאַחֲרִיתְךָ יִשְׂגֶּה מְאֹד"?! **he expounded "your latter end will greatly increase"?!**[3]

> This question drives the shiur. Yitzchak is the father of Israel, yet the Midrash calls him the "small beginning," and calls the sons of Keturah the "great increase." Rav Tzadok answers it only at the end of his ois, and we will too. First he asks what Avraham gave these sons and where he sent them.

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[1] Keturah is Hagar, according to Rav in Bereishis Rabbah 61:4. Mei HaShiloach reads Avraham's second marriage to her as a repair of the first (Mei HaShiloach I, Ki Seitzei 8):

אַחַר כָּל הַנִּסְיוֹנוֹת **after all his trials** נָשָׂא עוֹד הַפַּעַם אֶת הָגָר **he married Hagar again,** וּבֵירֵר **and made clear** שֶׁגַּם תְּחִלָּה **that the first time too** הָיָה בִּרְצוֹן הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ; **was by the will of Hashem.**

[2] Midrash Tanchuma, Chayei Sarah. Bereishis Rabbah 61:4 explains the name Keturah: her deeds were fragrant (mekuteres) like incense. Pri Tzaddik returns to this midrash in 6:5 (Part III).

[3] Kometz HaMinchah 2:59 starts from the same pasuk and sets Keturah's sons directly opposite Avraham (Kometz HaMinchah 2:59):

כִּי כָּל הַנְהָגוֹת אַבְרָהָם **for all of Avraham's ways** חוּץ לְדֶרֶךְ הַטֶּבַע, **were beyond the way of nature;** … כֵּן מִצַּד כִּשְׁפֵי לְעוּמַת זֶה **facing it,** מַדְרֵגָתוֹ בְּנִסִּים **so from his level of miracles** הוּכְרַח לִהְיוֹת מִצִּידוֹ **there had to be, on its side,** בְּנֵי קֶדֶם **the sorcery of the Bnei Kedem.**

He gives the reason a few lines earlier: creation needs concealment, כְּדֵי שֶׁיִּהְיֶה מָקוֹם לַבְּחִירָה. **so that there is room for free choice.**

II. The Gifts: A Name for Use in Impurity

The pasuk

בְּרֵאשִׁית כה, ה–ו · Bereishis 25:5–6

וַיִּתֵּן אַבְרָהָם **Avraham gave** אֶת כָּל אֲשֶׁר לוֹ **all that he had** לְיִצְחָק. **to Yitzchak.** וְלִבְנֵי הַפִּילַגְשִׁים **And to the sons of the concubines** אֲשֶׁר לְאַבְרָהָם **that Avraham had,** נָתַן אַבְרָהָם מַתָּנֹת; **Avraham gave gifts;** וַיְשַׁלְּחֵם **and he sent them away** מֵעַל יִצְחָק בְּנוֹ **from Yitzchak his son,** בְּעוֹדֶנּוּ חַי **while he was still alive,** קֵדְמָה **eastward,** אֶל אֶרֶץ קֶדֶם. **to the land of the East.**[4]

What were the gifts?

סַנְהֶדְרִין צא. · Sanhedrin 91a

אָמַר רַבִּי יִרְמְיָה בַּר אַבָּא: **Rabbi Yirmiyah bar Abba said:** מַאי מַתָּנוֹת? **What were the "gifts"?** שֵׁם טוּמְאָה. **a name of impurity.**[5] שֶׁמָּסַר לָהֶם **that he handed over to them** מְלַמֵּד **This teaches**

> The Gemara's answer seems to make the question harder. Would Avraham hand his sons a name of impurity?

Pri Tzaddik: a Name that works even in impurity

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ו׳ · Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:3

וְהוּא קָשֶׁה לוֹמַר **Now it is difficult to say** שֶׁיִּמְסוֹר לָהֶם אַבְרָהָם אֲבִינוּ **that Avraham our father would hand them,** עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם, **peace be upon him,** שֵׁם טוּמְאָה **a name of impurity** לַעֲשׂוֹת כִּישּׁוּף, **to practice sorcery,** שֶׁנֶּאֱסַר גַּם לִבְנֵי נֹחַ **which is forbidden even to the sons of Noach,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב

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[4]Where is "the land of the East"? קֶדֶם (kedem) means "east," and also "front" or "before," because the ancients oriented themselves facing the sunrise. (The Midrash in Part III plays on מִזְרָח, "east," literally the place where the sun shines.) In Tanach the Bnei Kedem are the peoples of the desert lands east and northeast of Eretz Yisrael, across the Yarden and out toward the Euphrates. On a modern map that is roughly eastern Jordan, Syria, northern Saudi Arabia and western Iraq. The pesukim place them this way:

Yaakov, on his way to Lavan in Charan (near today's border of Turkey and Syria): וַיִּשָּׂא יַעֲקֹב רַגְלָיו **Yaakov lifted his feet** וַיֵּלֶךְ אַרְצָה בְּנֵי קֶדֶם. **and went to the land of the Bnei Kedem** (Bereishis 29:1).

Bilam, from Pesor on the Euphrates (Bamidbar 22:5): מִן אֲרָם יַנְחֵנִי בָלָק **"From Aram Balak brought me,** מֶלֶךְ מוֹאָב **the king of Moav,** מֵהַרְרֵי קֶדֶם. **from the mountains of Kedem"** (Bamidbar 23:7).

Iyov: וַיְהִי הָאִישׁ הַהוּא **that man was** גָּדוֹל מִכֹּל בְּנֵי קֶדֶם. **the greatest of all the Bnei Kedem** (Iyov 1:3).

Desert raiders, together with Keturah's son Midian: וְעָלָה מִדְיָן וְעֲמָלֵק **Midian and Amalek came up,** וּבְנֵי קֶדֶם. **and the Bnei Kedem** (Shoftim 6:3); and together with Yishmael's son Kedar: קוּמוּ עֲלוּ אֶל קֵדָר, **"Arise, go up against Kedar,** וְשֹׁדְדוּ אֶת בְּנֵי קֶדֶם. **and plunder the Bnei Kedem"** (Yirmiyahu 49:28).

Keturah's sons fit this map. Midian (25:2) lived in northwest Arabia, east of the Gulf of Aqaba, and Dedan (25:3) was an oasis in the same region. Avraham sent them from Chevron southeast and east, into the Arabian desert, where their families mixed with the sons of Yishmael (see the note on milah in Part III).

[5]The setting in the Gemara: the sons of Yishmael and of Keturah came before Alexander of Macedon to claim a share in Eretz Yisrael. Geviha ben Pesisa answered from these pesukim: a father who gave gifts to his sons in his lifetime and sent them away from one another, does one have any claim on the other? The Gemara then asks what the gifts were.

בַּגְּמָרָא (סַנְהֶדְרִין נו:)! **as written in the Gemara (Sanhedrin 56b)!**[6] וְהָעִיקָּר **Rather, the main reading** כְּגִירְסַת הַ"פַּעֲנֵחַ רָזָא" **follows the version of the Pa'aneach Raza** (וְרַשְׁ"י בַּחוּמָּשׁ): **(and Rashi on the Chumash):** שֶׁמָּסַר לָהֶם "שֵׁם בְּטוּמְאָה", **"that he handed them a Name in impurity";**[7] וְהַיְינוּ שֶׁיָּדַע אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ **meaning that Avraham our father knew** שֶׁלֹּא יִהְיוּ טְהוֹרִים, **that they would not be pure,** וּמָסַר לָהֶם שֵׁם **and he handed them a Name** שֶׁיּוּכְלוּ לְהַזְכִּירוֹ **that they could invoke** אַף בְּטוּמְאָה, **even in impurity;** וְהַיְינוּ שֶׁיִּהְיֶה בָּהֶם **so that there would be in them** אֵיזֶה שׁוֹרֶשׁ קְדוּשָּׁה **some root of holiness** שֶׁיִּשָּׁאֵר מֵהֶם **that would remain from them** אַף לֶעָתִיד **even in the future,** שֶׁיִּהְיוּ גֵּרִים גְּרוּרִים. **so that there would be gerim gerurim, converts who come of themselves.**[8]

> So the gift was holy. Avraham knew where his sons were going, and he gave them a Name that would still work there, so that something of Avraham would survive in them. The Beis Yaakov reads the same words from the side of the one who receives.

Beis Yaakov: the receiver decides

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ל״ו · **Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 36**

וְלִבְנֵי הַפִּילַגְשִׁים אֲשֶׁר לְאַבְרָהָם נָתַן אַבְרָהָם **"And to the sons of the concubines that Avraham had, Avraham gave gifts," and so on.** עַל זֶה אָמְרוּ **On this they said** בְּשִׁשָּׁה סְדָרִים מַתְּנוֹת וְגוֹמֵר. **in the Talmud (Sanhedrin 91a):** שֵׁם טוּמְאָה מָסַר לָהֶם. **"He handed them a name of impurity."** וְהַעְנָיָן בָּזֶה הוּא, **The meaning is** שֶׁבֶּאֱמֶת מִצַּד הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ **that in truth, from Hashem's side,** אֵין דָּבָר טוּמְאָה **nothing impure** יוֹרֵד מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם, **comes down from heaven;** וְהַחִילּוּק הוּא **the difference lies** מִצַּד הַמְקַבֵּל הַטּוֹבָה **with the one who receives the good** וְהַשְׁפָּעַת הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ. **and the bounty of Hashem.** מִי שֶׁמַּכִּיר **One who recognizes,** בְּקַבָּלַת שִׁפְעַת טוֹבָה **in receiving abundant**

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[6] The Maharal asks the same question and answers that the gift was for removing sorcery, not using it (Gur Aryeh, Bereishis 25:6):

וְלֹא שֶׁרוֹצֶה לוֹמַר שֶׁנָּתַן לָהֶם לְהִשְׁתַּמֵּשׁ בְּכְשָׁפִים, **He does not mean that he gave them sorcery to use,** אֶלָּא לְסַלֵּק כְּשָׁפִים, **but to remove sorcery,** וְשֵׁד שֶׁנִּכְנַס בָּאָדָם – לְסַלְּקוֹ; **and a demon that entered a person – to drive it out;** מִי שֶׁהוּא מִתְעַסֵּק בְּכְשָׁפִים. הַתּוֹרָה חִיְּבָה מִיתָה **for the Torah made death the penalty for one who deals in sorcery.**

[7] Rashi on Bereishis 25:6 brings the Gemara as "a name of impurity." Pri Tzaddik cites the reading שֵׁם בְּטוּמְאָה ("a Name in impurity") from the Pa'aneach Raza and from Rashi on the Chumash; printed texts vary. The Baalei HaTosafos read it the same way (Da'as Zekenim, Bereishis 25:6):

שְׁמוֹת בְּטוּמְאָה מָסַר לָהֶם; **"He handed them Names in impurity" –** פֵּירוּשׁ, שֶׁיְּהוּ יְכוֹלִין לְהַזְכִּיר **meaning, that they could pronounce** שֵׁם הַמְפוֹרָשׁ **the explicit Name** בְּטוּמְאַת הַגּוּף **in bodily impurity,** וְלֹא יַזִּיק לָהֶם. **and it would not harm them.**

Chizkuni says the same. Sorcery is one of the prohibitions of Bnei Noach (Sanhedrin 56b), so Avraham could not have given them a name for sorcery.

[8] The Shelah reads "shem tumah" the same way: holiness at the root, impurity only in the spreading out (Shelah, Chayei Sarah, Torah Ohr 15):

וְדָבָר זֶה נִרְמָז בְּמָה שֶׁתֵּיבַת "פִּלַגְשִׁם" חָסֵר כְּתִיב, **This is hinted in the word "pilagshim" being written without a yud,** שֶׁרוֹמֵז לְשֵׁם טוּמְאָה; **which hints at "shem tumah":** כִּי הַקְּלִיפָּה בְּשָׁרְשָׁהּ – שֵׁם, **for the kelipah at its root is a Name,** וּבְהִתְפַּשְׁטוּת – טוּמְאָה; **and in its spreading out, impurity;** וְזֶהוּ שֵׁם טוּמְאָה. **and that is "shem tumah."** וְזֶהוּ נִרְמָז בְּתֵיבַת "פִּלַגְשִׁם": **This is hinted in the word "pilagshim":** דְּהַיְינוּ הַחֵצִי הוּא – "פְּלַג שֵׁם", **"pelag shem," half a Name –** כִּי תִּתְבַּטֵּל הַטּוּמְאָה. **but in the future it will be repaired,** אֲבָל לֶעָתִיד יִתּוּקַן, **for the impurity will be nullified.** שֵׁם; **that is, half of it is a Name;**

good, שֶׁלֹּא בְּכֹחוֹ וְעוֹצֶם יָדוֹ **that not his strength and the might of his hand** ,עָשָׂה לוֹ חָיִל **made him this wealth,** רַק הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ **but Hashem** הוּא הַנּוֹתֵן בּוֹ **is the One who gives him** ,כֹּחַ וְשִׂפְעַת טוֹבָה **strength and abundant good –** זוֹ הִיא טוֹבָה **this is good** ,מְלֵאָה קְדוּשָּׁה **filled with holiness;** וְהַמְקַבֵּלָהּ **and the one who receives it** הוּא בֶּן חוֹרִין **is free** ,בְּקַבָּלַת הַטּוֹבָה **in receiving the good,** מֵאַחַר שֶׁמַּכִּיר **since he recognizes** ,שֶׁמִּצִּדּוֹ אֵין לוֹ שׁוּם כֹּחַ **that on his own he has no power;** מִמֵּילָא **so of itself** .אֵינָנּוּ מְשׁוּקָע וְכָפוּף בָּהּ **he is neither sunk in it nor bound to it.**[9] … וְהָעִנְיָן בָּזֶה הוּא, **The meaning is** שֶׁמִּי שֶׁנִּדְמֶה לוֹ **that one who imagines** שֶׁבְּכֹחוֹ וְעוֹצֶם יָדוֹ **that his strength and the might of his hand** ,עָשָׂה לוֹ חָיִל **made him this wealth** אָזַי הוּא כָּפוּף **is then bound to** ,וּמְשׁוּקָע בְּהַטּוֹבָה **and sunk in the good;** וְכַאֲשֶׁר יְקַבְּלָהּ **and when he receives it,** הוּא עָרִיק מִקַּמֵּי מָארֵיהּ **he is running from his Master –**[10] .זֶה נִקְרָא שֵׁם טוּמְאָה **this is called a name of impurity.**[11] וְלָזֶה כְּתִיב כָּאן **That is why it is written here** ,מַתְּנֹת חָסֵר ו׳ **“matanos” without a vav,** ,דְּאוֹת אֱמֶת **the secret of the sign of truth;** כִּי אוֹת ו׳ מוֹרֶה **for the letter vav shows** עַל חַיִּים שֶׁל אֱמֶת **true life** .מֵהַמָּקוֹר **from the source.**[12] … וַיְשַׁלְּחֵם מֵעַל יִצְחָק בְּנוֹ **“He sent them away from Yitzchak his son** בְּעוֹדֶנּוּ חַי **while he was still alive,** .קֵדְמָה אֶל אֶרֶץ קֶדֶם **eastward, to the land of the East.”** הַיְינוּ אַף שֶׁהָיוּ **That is: even though they were** ,זֶה אֵצֶל זֶה **near one another,** אֲבָל הַפֵּירוּד וְהַחִילּוּק **the separation and difference** שֶׁבֵּינֵיהֶם **between them** .הוּא כִּרְחוֹק מִזְרָח מִמַּעֲרָב **is as far as east is from west.**[13]

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[9]Here the Beis Yaakov brings the Zohar (Tetzaveh 180b) on three kinds of names: supernal holy names that stand through the will of the spirit and heart, without speech; lower holy names that stand through speech and the intention drawn to them; and names of the Other Side, which stand only through an action below, “like Bilam and those people of the East.”

[10]Applied to our time (this is an application, not the Beis Yaakov’s own words). His test does not depend on what a practice is called, but on whether the one who receives it ties it back to the Giver. A spiritual technique used only as a tool – meditation sold for calm or success alone, “manifesting,” astrology – may draw on something real; but received as one’s own power, cut off from Hashem, it is what he calls “a name of impurity.” The Taz says the same of all wisdom given to the nations: once given, it has “no more attachment to the Giver” (see Part V). The Zohar warns that the books of the East turn a person away from the service of Hashem (see Part III).

When Eastern meditation movements spread among Jews in the 1970s, the Lubavitcher Rebbe called them “cults bordering on, and in some respects actual, Avodah Zarah” (memo, Teves 5738). In a talk in 1979 he pointed to the “burning incense and bowing to a Guru” that came with them, and asked doctors and psychologists to develop a kosher form built on Torah ideas (translated on the Kavvanah blog). Whether a particular practice is permitted is a question for a rav.

[11]Beis Yaakov 33 gives a second reading (Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 33):

הָעִנְיָן בָּזֶה, **The point is** דְּהִנֵּה בְּאֵלּוּ הַתּוֹלְדוֹת **that in these offspring** לֹא הָיָה אוֹר כְּלָל, **there was no light at all,** מִפְּנֵי שֶׁנּוֹלְדוּ מֵאַבְרָהָם **because they were born to Avraham** ,אַחַר שֶׁנִּשְׁלַם **after he was complete;** … הַיְינוּ שֶׁלֹּא הָיָה בָּהֶם קְדוּשָּׁה, **that is, since there was no holiness in them,** הָיָה בָּהֶם שֵׁם טוּמְאָה. מִמֵּילָא **of itself a name of impurity was in them.**

In 33:2 he adds why Avraham fathered them at all: these nations were fit to be born from Yitzchak, but from his gevurah they would have oppressed Israel. Born from Avraham’s chesed, the opposite of gevurah, the nations oppose one another, and Israel has respite between them (Zohar, Mishpatim 95a).

[12]The Beis Yaakov continues with the Zohar (Vayechi 241b): the “sign of truth” is the letter vav, “for life dwells in it.” The vav is connection; one who lacks it is cut off from the source. So Efron is written with a vav while he was still weighing whether to sell the holy place, and without it (עֶפְרֹן , 23:16) once he chose the money.

[13]In kabbalah, the Recanati reads the two gifts of these pesukim as the two sides of Avraham’s power (Recanati on the Torah, Chayei Sarah):

> The two readings agree that the gift came from Hashem through Avraham. Pri Tzaddik speaks of what Avraham planted in his sons. Beis Yaakov speaks of the one who receives it: a gift received as one's own achievement becomes a "name of impurity." Both end with the same distance, east of Yitzchak. The next question is what was waiting in the East.

III. Eastward: Where the Oral Torah Went into Exile

Two exiled wisdoms: Egypt and the East

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ו׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:4**

מֵחָכְמַת כָּל בְּנֵי קֶדֶם וְהִנֵּה כְּתִיב: **Now it is written: "Shlomo's wisdom excelled the wisdom of all the Bnei Kedem**[14] (מְלָכִים א ה, י). וּמִכֹּל חָכְמַת מִצְרָיִם **and all the wisdom of Egypt" (I Melachim 5:10).** וְהַיְינוּ דִּכְתִיב: **This is as it is written:** "וְאַתָּה מְחַיֶּה אֶת כֻּלָּם" (נְחֶמְיָה ט, ו), **"And You give life to them all" (Nechemiah 9:6);** וְעִיקַּר הַחַיִּים **and the essence of life** הוּא דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה: **is words of Torah.** כָּל הַתּוֹרָה שֶׁבִּכְתָב, וּבְמִצְרַיִם הָיָה בְּגָלוּת **In Egypt there was in exile all of the Written Torah,** וְעַל זֶה נֶאֱמַר: **and of this it is said:** "וְאַחֲרֵי כֵן יֵצְאוּ **"And afterwards they will go out** – בְּרֻכוּשׁ גָּדוֹל" (בְּרֵאשִׁית טו, יד) **with great wealth" (Bereishis 15:14)** – וְהַיְינוּ כְּשֶׁיּוֹצִיאוּ מֵהֶם **that is, when they draw out of them** כָּל הַחַיּוּת וְהַקְּדוּשָׁה, **all the vitality and holiness;** שֶׁעָשָׂאוּהָ כְּמְצוּדָה שֶׁאֵין בָּהּ דָּגִים וְכִמְצוּלָה שֶׁאֵין בָּהּ דָּגָן **for they made it like a trap with no grain in it, and like a deep with no fish in it,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ (בְּרָכוֹת ט:), **as they said (Berachos 9b)** – וְהַיְינוּ כָּל הַחַיִּים, **that is, all of life:** "דָּגִים" שֶׁעַל זֶה מְרַמֵּז שֶׁעַל זֶה רִאשׁוֹנָה **this is what "fish" hints at, for of them the Torah first uses** לְשׁוֹן "נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה" (בְּרֵאשִׁית א, כ) **the term "living soul" (Bereishis**

וְסוֹד הָעִנְיָן הוּא, כִּי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם הָיוּ בְּיָדוֹ כֹּחוֹת הַטָּהֳרָה וְכֹחוֹת הַטּוּמְאָה: הֵם כֹּחוֹת הָעֲרְלָה, וְהַטּוּמְאָה מִבַּחוּץ, הַטָּהֳרָה בְּפָנִים... קְלִיפּוֹת אִילָן הָעֶלְיוֹן. הַנִּקְרָאִים מָסַר לִבְנֵי הַפִּלַגְשִׁים... שֶׁלֹּא יִכָּנְסוּ טְמֵאִים בַּהֵיכָל. **The secret of the matter is that Avraham our father, peace be upon him, held in his hand the powers of purity and the powers of impurity – the powers of the orlah, purity within…, and impurity outside, which are called the shells of the supernal tree.** … **The powers of impurity …he handed to the sons of the concubines…, – "and he sent them away from Yitzchak his son" – so that the impure would not enter the Sanctuary.**

[14]What was "the wisdom of the Bnei Kedem"? Rashi on this pasuk (Rashi, I Melachim 5:10):

מַה הִיא חָכְמַת בְּנֵי קֶדֶם? יוֹדְעִים בְּמַזָּלוֹת, וְכוֹלֵי, כִּדְאִיתָא בִּפְסִיקְתָּא דְּפָרָה אֲדֻמָּה. **What is the wisdom of the Bnei Kedem? They knew the constellations, and so on, as found in the Pesikta of Parah Adumah.**

The Radak (Radak, I Melachim 5:10):

בְּנֵי מִזְרָח הָיוּ יְדוּעִים בְּחָכְמָה, וְכֵן כְּתִיב: "כִּי מָלְאוּ מִקֶּדֶם". וּבְדִבְרֵי רַבּוֹתֵינוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה: שֶׁהָיוּ יוֹדְעִים בַּמַּזָּלוֹת וַעֲרוּמִים בַּטַּיָּיר; פֵּירוּשׁ, בִּלְשׁוֹן הָעוֹפוֹת... וְכֵן בְּנֵי מִצְרַיִם הָיוּ יוֹדְעִים בְּחָכְמָה, שֶׁבָּהּ הָיוּ נִקְרָאִים הַחַרְטֻמִּים. **בְּנֵי מִזְרָח The people of the East, הָיוּ יְדוּעִים בְּחָכְמָה were known for wisdom, וְכֵן כְּתִיב: as it is written: "כִּי מָלְאוּ מִקֶּדֶם". וּבְדִבְרֵי רַבּוֹתֵינוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה: And in the words of our Sages, of blessed memory: מַה הָיְתָה חָכְמַת בְּנֵי קֶדֶם? What was the wisdom of the Bnei Kedem? שֶׁהָיוּ יוֹדְעִים בַּמַּזָּלוֹת That they knew the constellations; וַעֲרוּמִים בַּטַּיָּיר; פֵּירוּשׁ, בִּלְשׁוֹן הָעוֹפוֹת... that is, in the language of birds… וְכֵן בְּנֵי מִצְרַיִם And the Egyptians too, הָיוּ יוֹדְעִים בְּחָכְמָה, שֶׁבָּהּ הָיוּ נִקְרָאִים were known for a wisdom for which they were called הַחַרְטֻמִּים. the "chartumim," the magicians.**

The pasuk the Radak cites (Yeshayahu 2:6) goes on: "and soothsayers like the Philistines." The wisdom of the East, then, was astrology and the reading of omens: real knowledge of how forces from above flow into the world, used to foresee and to control what happens. This is what Rav Tzadok calls the wisdom of idolatry, "drawing down influx and kinds of sorcery" (Likkutei Maamarim, quoted two notes below), and it is the opposite of Avraham, who lived above the stars ("Go out from your astrology," Shabbos 156a).

1:20), שֶׁבָּהֶם שׁוֹרֶשׁ חַיִּים, **for in them is the root of life;** וְ"דָגָן" הַיְינוּ קִיּוּם הַחַיִּים **and "grain" is what sustains life.** וְעַל יְדֵי כֵן **Through this** זָכוּ לְמַתַּן תּוֹרָה, **they merited the giving of the Torah,** וְזֶהוּ הָרְכוּשׁ גָּדוֹל; **and that is the "great wealth."**[15] – וּבְ"חָכְמַת כָּל בְּנֵי קֶדֶם" **And in "the wisdom of all the Bnei Kedem" –** שָׁם הָיָה בְּגָלוּת תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה, **there was in exile the Oral Torah;** וְהֵם נֶגֶד תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה, **"one opposite the other,"** "זֶה לְעֻמַּת זֶה" **and they are in the kelipah,** בַּקְלִיפָּה **facing the Oral Torah.**[16] As it says in the holy Zohar דְּאִיתָא בַּזֹּהַר הַקָּדוֹשׁ (סוֹף פָּרָשָׁה זוֹ קלג עַמּוּד ב): **(end of this parsha, 133b):** "דְּהָא בְּאִינּוּן הָרְרֵי קֶדֶם" **"For in those mountains of the East** אִינּוּן דְּאוֹלְפִין חַרְשִׁין **are those who teach sorcery** לִבְנֵי נָשָׁא, **to mankind,** וּמֵהַהִיא אֶרֶץ קֶדֶם **and from that land of the East** נָפְקוּ לָבָן וּבְעוֹר. עַיֵּין שָׁם, **came Lavan and Be'or** וּבִלְעָם בְּנוֹ", **and Bilam his son" – see there.**[17] וּבִלְעָם הָיָה **And Bilam was** דַּעַת דְּקִלְקִיפָּה, **the Da'as of the kelipah,**[18] כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב וְעַל זֶה הַכָּתוּב אוֹמֵר. **as written in the holy Zohar** בַּזֹּהַר הַקָּדוֹשׁ (חֵלֶק ג קצד עַמּוּד א) **(III 194a). Of**

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[15]Tzidkas HaTzaddik 249 follows the wisdom of Egypt the other way, into Avraham's house (Tzidkas HaTzaddik 249):

וְזֶה טַעַם שֶׁקִּבֵּל אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ מַתָּנוֹת מִמִּצְרַיִם, **And this is why Avraham our father received gifts from Egypt:** … רַק שֶׁהוּא חָשַׁק לְחָכְמָה שֶׁלָּהֶם, שֶׁקָּלַט הַחֵשֶׁק **only he longed for wisdom that was theirs, he took in the passion** לְחָכְמַת אֱמֶת. **for true wisdom.**

Of Shlomo, whose wisdom "excelled all the wisdom of Egypt," he says the outside wisdom was only on loan: כִּי בֶאֱמֶת חָכְמַת חִיצוֹנוֹת הוּא חֶלְקָם, **For in truth outside wisdom is their portion;** רַק שֶׁהָיְתָה בִּשְׁאֵלָה לְשָׁעָה **only it was on loan for a time** לִבְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל **to the Children of Israel,** לְקִבּוּעַ בְּלִבָּם **in order to fix in their hearts,** עַל יְדֵי זֶה **through it,** חָכְמַת הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ. **the wisdom of Hashem.**

Once Shlomo wrote Mishlei, clarifying the wisdom of the Torah, it was no longer needed, "and each thing returned to its proper place."

[16]Rav Tzadok develops this in Likkutei Maamarim (Upon Completion of the Talmud 5):

וּבַעֲבוֹדָה זָרָה יֵשׁ גַּם כֵּן חָכְמוֹת גְּדוֹלוֹת **And in idolatry there are also great wisdoms** שֶׁל הוֹרָדַת הַשְׁפָּעָה **of drawing down influx,** וּמִינֵי כִּישׁוּף **and kinds of sorcery,** וְהִיא חָכְמַת בְּנֵי קֶדֶם **and this is the wisdom of the Bnei Kedem,** כַּנּוֹדָע; **as is known.** … וְאֵין נִקְרָא תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **And nothing is called Oral Torah** אֶלָּא הַחָכְמָה הַנּוֹבַעַת **except the wisdom that wells up** מִלֵּב קְדוֹשֵׁי יִשְׂרָאֵל; **from the heart of Israel's holy ones.**

That is the sense of "he was wiser than all men… than all the Bnei Kedem": שֶׁיֵּשׁ הַכָּרַת יִתְרוֹן **there the advantage is seen** שֶׁל זֶה לְעֻמַּת זֶה. **of the one over the other.**

[17]The Zohar there describes what this wisdom looked like. Rabbi Abba said (Zohar, Vayera):

יוֹמָא חַד אִתְעַרְעָנָא בְּחַד מָתָא מִן בְּנֵי קֶדֶם, **One day I happened upon a town of those who were of the Bnei Kedem,** דְּהָווּ יָדְעִין מִיּוֹמֵי קַדְמָאֵי... מֵהַהִיא חָכְמְתָא **they had known since ancient days…; of the wisdom** וְאָמְרוּ לִי **and they told me** וְקָרִיבוּ לִי חַד סִפְרָא. **and they brought me a book.**

In the book he found (5:83):

כָּל אִנּוּן עוֹבָדִין וּפוּלְחָנִין, וּמַזָּלֵי דְּכוֹכְבַיָּא **I found in it all the rites and services of the stars and constellations,** וְהֵיאַךְ רְעוּתָא לְאִתְכַּוָּונָא בְּהוּ, וּמִלִּין דְּאִצְטְרִיכוּ לוֹן, **and how to direct the will to them, the words they require,** בְּגִין לְאַמְשָׁכָא לוֹן לְגַבַּיְיהוּ. **in order to draw them down to oneself.**

The book taught that a person draws down from above whatever he cleaves to, holy or impure, through words, deeds and intention (5:81–82). Rabbi Abba told his students (5:88):

אֲבָל אִית לְכוּ אִתְרַחֲקָא לְמִלִּין דְּאוֹרַיְיתָא; **but you must keep far to the words of Torah;** בָּנַי, קְרִיבָא דְּא **My sons, this is close** לְאִלֵּין פּוּלְחָנִין... **to these services…,** בְּגִין דְּלָא יִסְטֵי לִבַּייכוּ מֵאִנּוּן סִפְרִין, **so that your hearts not turn aside from those books,** דִּילְמָא חַס וְשָׁלוֹם תִּסְטוּן מִבָּתַר פּוּלְחָנָא דְקוּדְשָׁא **lest, Heaven forbid, you turn aside from the service of the Holy One, blessed be He.** בְּרִיךְ הוּא.

And he explains why it is so close to Torah: it came from Avraham (5:89):

this the pasuk says – דְּ"וַתֵּרֶב חָכְמַת שְׁלֹמֹה" **that "the wisdom of Shlomo"** – שֶׁהִיא חָכְמָה תַּתָּאָה, **which is the Lower Wisdom,** – תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **the Oral Torah** – "וַתֵּרֶב" **"excelled"** (נִתְרַבְּתָה **(it grew** מֵחָכְמַת כָּל בְּנֵי קֶדֶם" **from his drawing out** הַנִּיצוֹצוֹת הַקְּדוֹשִׁים**) the holy sparks)** **"beyond the wisdom of all the Bnei Kedem** ;"וּמִכֹּל חָכְמַת מִצְרָיִם **and all the wisdom of Egypt."**[19] וְגַם תּוֹרָה הָיָה בַּקְּלִיפָּה **And though the wisdom of Egypt was in the kelipah** וְאַף דְּחָכְמַת מִצְרַיִם זָכַר גַּם חָכְמַת מִצְרַיִם **it mentions the wisdom of Egypt too,** שֶׁבִּכְתָב, **opposite the Written Torah,** שֶׁשָּׁרְשָׁהּ מִתּוֹרָה שֶׁבִּכְתָב. דְּתוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **because the Oral Torah has its root in the Written Torah.**

> Now Keturah herself enters the picture. She is Hagar, and her root is in Egypt; her children were sent to the East. Between them, mother and sons touch both exiled wisdoms.

Keturah's root, and the Name she carried east

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אוֹת ו׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:5**

וּקְטוּרָה, **And Keturah,** אַף שֶׁהָיְתָה צְנוּעָה בְּמַעֲשֶׂיהָ **though she was modest in her deeds,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ בַּמִּדְרָשׁ, **as they said in the Midrash** ("שֶׁנָּאִים מַעֲשֶׂיהָ כִּקְטֹרֶת") **("her deeds were as pleasing as incense")** – מִכָּל מָקוֹם **nevertheless** שָׁרְשָׁהּ הָיָה **her root was** מִקְּלִיפַּת מִצְרַיִם, **from the kelipah of Egypt,** שֶׁהָיְתָה שִׁפְחָה **"This is Hagar,"** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ שָׁם: "זוֹ הָגָר", **as they said there:** מִצְרִית; **who was an Egyptian maidservant.** וְזַרְעָהּ שִׁילַּח אַבְרָהָם **And her offspring Avraham sent** וּמָסַר לָהֶם[20] **and handed them** – שֵׁם בְּטוּמְאָה **a Name in**

בְּגִין דִּבְנֵי קֶדֶם חֲכִימִין הֲווֹ, דְּאִתְּמַסַּר לוֹן חָכְמְתָא דָּא וִירוּתָא דְּאִתְיְרִיתוּ מֵאַבְרָהָם, דִּיהַב לִבְנֵי פִּלַגְשִׁים...; וּלְבָתַר אִתְמַשְׁכוּ בְּהַהִיא חָכְמָה לְכַמָּה סְטָרִין.

For the Bnei Kedem were wise, and they inherited from Avraham, who gave it to the sons of the concubines…; and afterwards they were drawn by that wisdom in many directions.

Lavan, the first man of the East whom the Zohar names, used this wisdom in the Torah itself. He told Yaakov (Bereishis 30:27):

נִחַשְׁתִּי, וַיְבָרְכֵנִי ה' בִּגְלָלֶךָ.

"I have learned by divination that Hashem has blessed me because of you."

He knew real things about how blessing flows, and he learned them by divination, not by serving Hashem.

[18]Bilam is the clearest case of this wisdom: real spiritual power, offered for hire. The Torah calls him וְיֹדֵעַ דַּעַת עֶלְיוֹן **"one who knows the knowledge of the Most High"** (Bamidbar 24:16). And the people who came to hire him against Israel were Moav and Midian, Keturah's son (Bamidbar 22:7):

וַיֵּלְכוּ זִקְנֵי מוֹאָב, וְזִקְנֵי מִדְיָן, וְקֶסָמִים בְּיָדָם.

The elders of Moav went, and the elders of Midian, with divinations in their hand.

Keturah's son had gone east, and now his descendants bought the power of the East and turned it against the children of Yitzchak. This is the "Da'as of the kelipah": knowledge of the Most High with no attachment to Him.

[19]Compare Likkutei Maamarim, On the Book of Joshua 5: the Sages wished to count Shlomo among those who lose their share in the World to Come, and Bilam, master of the wisdom of the East, was counted in his place, "for of King Solomon it is said: his wisdom excelled the wisdom of all the children of the East."

[20]Where is this wisdom today? Rav Tzadok and the Izhbitz writers do not say. Several contemporary teachers identify Avraham's gifts with the religions of the Far East and their meditative disciplines. Rav Pinchas Winston writes that Keturah's sons "learned to meditate and to create a high level of spiritual sensitivity," which he takes to be the basis of most Eastern religions; R' Dov Ber Cohen points to Hindu figures whose names resemble Avraham and Sarah (both cited in Aish, "Abraham's Impure Gifts to His Children").

These are modern suggestions, not traditional teachings, and the popular claim that the Hindus descend from Keturah's sons has no classical source. The Bnei Kedem of Tanach lived much closer, in the Arabian and Syrian deserts (see the note

impurity – דְּאַף שֶׁהֵם בְּטוּמְאָה **so that even while they are in impurity,** יִהְיֶה בָּהֶן שׁוֹרֶשׁ קְדוּשָׁה **there would be in them a root of holiness;** וּמֵהֶם יוֹצִיאוּ יִשְׂרָאֵל **and from them Israel would draw out** הַחַיּוּת וְהַנִּיצוֹצוֹת הַקְּדוֹשִׁים שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה, **the vitality and the holy sparks of the Oral Torah;**[21] וּמֵהֶם יִשָּׁאֵר **and from them would remain** גֵּרִים גְּרוּרִין לֶעָתִיד. **gerim gerurim in the future.**[22] … וְעַל כָּרְחָךְ **Perforce,** שֶׁיֵּשׁ בָּהֶם שׁוֹרֶשׁ קְדוּשָׁה **there is in them a root of holiness** יוֹתֵר מִבְּנֵי עֵשָׂו שֶׁפְּטוּרִין מִמִּילָה! **more than in the sons of Esav, who are exempt from milah!**

"Shine what you can shine": the coal of Yitzchak

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אוֹת ו׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:6**

And this is the meaning וְזֶה הַמְּכֻוָּן **of what they said** בְּמַה שֶׁאָמְרוּ (פְּרָשָׁה סא, ז) **in Midrash Rabbah (61:7):** בַּמִּדְרָשׁ רַבָּה **"He sent them away from Yitzchak his son…** "וַיְשַׁלְּחֵם מֵעַל יִצְחָק בְּנוֹ… **eastward, to the land of the East" –** קֵדְמָה אֶל אֶרֶץ קֶדֶם" – **he said to them:** אָמַר לָהֶם: כָּל מַה **As far east as you can go (lehazriach, "to shine"),** שֶׁאַתֶּם יְכוֹלִים לְהַזְרִיחַ, **go east (tazrichu),** תַּזְרִיחוּ **so that you are not burned** שֶׁלֹּא תִּכָּווּ בְּגַחֶלְתּוֹ שֶׁל יִצְחָק. **by the coal of Yitzchak. By its plain sense,** וְלִפְשׁוּטוֹ אֵינוֹ מְדוּקְדָּק לְשׁוֹן דִּקְאֵי עַל רוּחַ מִזְרָח, **referring to the eastern direction,** **the wording is not precise:** ;"לְהַזְרִיחַ תַּזְרִיחוּ" **"lehazriach tazrichu" – to cause to shine.** אֶלָּא הַמְּכֻוָּן: **Rather, the meaning is:** לְהוֹפִיעַ אוֹר, – "לְהַזְרִיחַ" **"lehazriach" – to make light appear;** – "תַּזְרִיחוּ" **"tazrichu" –** תָּאִירוּ אוֹר **shine light** מֵהַשֵּׁם שֶׁמָּסַר לָהֶם, **from the Name he handed them;** וְהוּא כְּדֵי שֶׁיִּשָּׁאֵר **so that there would remain** מֵהֶם הַשְׁאָרָה **a remnant of them** לִהְיוֹת גֵּרִים גְּרוּרִים; **to become gerim gerurim.**[23] וְאָמַר **And he said,** "שֶׁלֹּא תִּכָּווּ **"so that you are not burned** – "בְּגַחֶלְתּוֹ שֶׁל יִצְחָק" **by the coal of Yitzchak" –** הַיְינוּ אֵשׁ דִּקְדוּשָׁה **meaning the fire of holiness,** שֶׁהוּא תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה, **which is the Oral Torah,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ (תַּעֲנִית ד.): **as they said (Taanis 4a):** "הַאי צוּרְבָּא מֵרַבָּנָן דְּרָתַח, **"A young Torah scholar who grows heated –** אוֹרַיְיתָא הִיא **it is the Torah,** דְּקָא מְרַתְּחָא לֵיהּ **that heats him,** שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: **as it says:** הֲלוֹא כֹה דְבָרִי כָּאֵשׁ **'Is not My word like fire?'** ;"(יִרְמְיָה כג, כט)

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on Bereishis 25:6 in Part II); the identification rests on the character of the wisdom, not on the map. And on that the classical sources are clear: it is spiritual power drawn down by technique and intention (the Zohar's book of the East, above in this part), close enough to Torah to be confused with it, and for that reason to be kept at a distance.

[21]The Me'or Einayim (Chernobyl) explains "shem tumah" as Torah that fell among the nations, which only the seed of Yitzchak can lift out (Me'or Einayim, Noach):

כִּי **what fell among the nations…;** מַה שֶׁנָּפַל בֵּין הָאוּמּוֹת… **and gather** וּלְלַקֵּט **to sift out the Torah** לְבָרֵר אֶת הַתּוֹרָה, וְהֵן, אַדְרַבָּה, **while they, on the contrary, defile, as it were, among the nations** כְּבָיְכוֹל מְטַמְּאִין בְּאוּמּוֹת הָעוֹלָם אֶת הַתֵּיבוֹת שֶׁנִּקְרָא שְׁמוֹתָיו שֶׁל הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא; **the words that are called a "Name" –** שֵׁם **is the Names of the Holy One;** וְזֶהוּ חַיּוּתָן, **and this is their life:** שֶׁיֵּשׁ לָהֶם אֲחִיזָה בִּקְדוּשָׁה. **that they have a hold in holiness.**

has the power יֵשׁ לָהֶם הַכֹּחַ **for the seed of Yitzchak** זַרְעוֹ שֶׁל יִצְחָק **to sift and to whiten;** לְבָרֵר וּלְלַבֵּן; **for the whole Torah** כִּי הַתּוֹרָה כּוּלָּהּ

He adds that this is why Yaakov "went to the land of the Bnei Kedem" (Bereishis 29:1), where Avraham had sent the sons of the concubines: to lift those fallen words back to their root.

[22]Pri Tzaddik's proof: the Gemara (Sanhedrin 59b) includes the sons of Keturah in the mitzvah of milah, and the Rambam (Hilchos Melachim 10:8) rules that their descendants, now mixed with Yishmael, are obligated in every generation. The servants circumcised with Avraham, by contrast, left the covenant after his death (Pirkei DeRabbi Eliezer 29).

[23]The Gemara says the same of every exile (Pesachim 87b):

The Holy One, blessed be He, did not exile לֹא הִגְלָה הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא **Israel among the nations** אֶת יִשְׂרָאֵל לְבֵין הָאוּמּוֹת **except so that** אֶלָּא כְּדֵי **converts would be added to them.** שֶׁיִּתּוֹסְפוּ עֲלֵיהֶם גֵּרִים.

(Yirmiyah 23:29).” "וּדְבָרִי" **And “My word”** ,הַיְינוּ תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **is the Oral Torah,** :כְּמוֹ שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר **as it says:** "וְאָשִׂם דְּבָרַי בְּפִיךָ" **“I have put My words in your mouth”** ;(יְשַׁעְיָה נא, טז) **(Yeshayah 51:16);** וְכֵן כָּתוּב **and so it is written** :בְּהַקְדָּמַת תִּקּוּנֵי זֹהַר **in the Introduction to Tikkunei Zohar:** "וְכַד אִתְנְטִילַת מִגְּבוּרָה **“And when it is taken from Gevurah** (מִדַּת יִצְחָק) **(the attribute of Yitzchak),** אִתְקְרִיאַת תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **it is called the Oral Torah,”** .וְכוּלֵי **and so on.**

> Avraham sent his sons away to protect them. Close to Yitzchak, the fire of the Oral Torah would have burned them. Far away, they could shine whatever light the Name gave them, and that light would one day bring some of them back as converts.

IV. “Sons of Keturah”: Holding Torah Without Grasping It

Rabbi Tarfon’s rebuke

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אוֹת ו׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:2**

אַךְ הָעִנְיָן **But the matter is** עַל פִּי מַה שֶׁאָמְרוּ בַּגְּמָרָא **according to what they said in the Gemara** :(זְבָחִים סב:) **(Zevachim 62b):** קָרֵי עֲלַיְיהוּ: "בְּנֵי קְטוּרָה!" **“He applied to them: “Sons of Keturah!’”** וּפֵירֵשׁ רַשְׁ"י: **And Rashi explains:** ,בְּנֵי אַבְרָהָם אַתֶּם **You are sons of Avraham,** אֲבָל לֹא כְּזַרְעוֹ **but not like the seed** יִצְחָק וְיַעֲקֹב. **of Yitzchak and Yaakov.** :וְאַחַר כָּךְ אִיתָא שָׁם **And afterwards it says there:** "בְּנֵי אֲחָתֵיהּ דְּרַבִּי טַרְפוֹן הָווּ יָתְבֵי קַמֵּיהּ... **“The sons of Rabbi Tarfon’s sister … were sitting before him…** :פָּתַח וְאָמַר **He opened and said:** וְיָסַף אַבְרָהָם וַיִּקַּח אִשָּׁה **‘And Avraham again took a wife,** ,וּשְׁמָהּ יוֹחָנִי. **and her name was Yochani.’** :אָמְרוּ לֵיהּ **They said to him:** קְטוּרָה כְּתִיב! **‘Keturah is written!’** :קָרֵי עֲלַיְיהוּ **He applied to them:** "בְּנֵי קְטוּרָה!"[24] :וְיֵשׁ לְהָבִין **We must understand:** קָרוּ לָהוּ "בְּנֵי **just because they did not know the halachah,** וְכִי מִפְּנֵי שֶׁלֹּא יָדְעוּ בַּהֲלָכָה **did he call them “sons of Keturah”?** :גַּם בַּמַּהַרְשָׁ"א הִקְשָׁה **The Maharsha also asks:** לָמָּה קְטוּרָה"? **why did he not call them “sons of Esav,”** לֹא קְרָאָם "בְּנֵי עֵשָׂו", **who, though they are** בְּנֵי שֶׁאַף **sons of Avraham and Yitzchak,** אַבְרָהָם וְיִצְחָק, אֵינָם בְּנֵי יַעֲקֹב? **are not sons of Yaakov?**

The answer

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אוֹת ו׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:7**

וְזֶה הָעִנְיָן **And this is why** שֶׁקָּרָא רַבִּי טַרְפוֹן **Rabbi Tarfon called** לְהָנָּהוּ דְּמַחֲכוּ עָלֵיהּ **those who laughed at him** :וְלֹא הֵבִינוּ כַּוָּנָתוֹ **and did not understand his intent:** "בְּנֵי קְטוּרָה!" **“Sons of Keturah!”** – (וְלֹא בְּנֵי עֵשָׂו) **(and not “sons of Esav”) –** דִּכְמוֹ בִּבְנֵי קְטוּרָה **for just as with the sons of Keturah,** שֶׁהָיָה בְּשָׁרְשָׁם **in whose root there were** דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה **words of Torah** ,דְּתוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **of the Oral Torah,** ,רַק הֵם לֹא זָכוּ לָזֶה **only they did not merit it,** וּשְׁלֹמֹה הוֹצִיא מֵהֶם **and Shlomo drew out of them** – הַתּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **the Oral Torah** – כֵּן גַּם בָּכֶם **so too in you** ,יֵשׁ דִּבְרֵי תוֹרָה **there are words of Torah,** וְלֹא זְכִיתֶם לְהָבִין! **and you have not merited to understand!** … וְהֵם לֹא הֵבִינוּ אֶת כַּוָּנָתוֹ **And they did not understand his intent,** :וְאָמְרוּ לֵיהּ כְּפָשׁוּטוֹ **and said to him plainly:** "קְטוּרָה כְּתִיב!" **“Keturah is written!”** וְלָכֵן קָרֵי עֲלַיְיהוּ **So he applied to them:** "בְּנֵי

[24] Pri Tzaddik also explains the name Yochani: Yochana was the chief of Egypt’s sorcerers (Menachos 85a), and Yochani bas Retivi was a sorceress (Sotah 22a). Rabbi Tarfon was hinting that Keturah’s root was the sorcery of Egypt (6:7). Kometz HaMinchah 2:59 explains the name the same way.

קְטוּרָה!", **"Sons of Keturah!"** שֶׁלֹּא הֵבִינוּ **for they did not grasp** עוֹמֶק כַּוָּנָתוֹ **the depth of his intent** בְּתוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה. **in the Oral Torah.**

> Rabbi Tarfon did not call them sons of Esav, because his point was not that they lacked Torah. A son of Keturah carries the sparks of the Oral Torah and cannot read them. His nephews knew the pasuk and missed the hint. The rebuke fits anyone who holds the words of Torah and misses their depth.

V. Yishmael: The Wisdom of Nature

> The parsha closes with a second family outside Avraham's house. Yishmael's wisdom is of another kind: not hidden Torah, but the wisdom of the natural world. The Izhbitzer reads it straight out of the names of his sons.

The names of Yishmael's sons

מֵי הַשִּׁילוֹחַ, חֵלֶק א, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה · **Mei HaShiloach I, Chayei Sarah 5**

אֲשֶׁר וְאֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת יִשְׁמָעֵאל בֶּן אַבְרָהָם **"These are the generations of Yishmael, son of Avraham,** לְאַבְרָהָם. יָלְדָה הָגָר הַמִּצְרִית שִׁפְחַת שָׂרָה, **whom Hagar the Egyptian, Sarah's maidservant, bore to Avraham."** (תְּהִלִּים קיא, ו): כְּתִיב **It is written (Tehillim 111:6):** "כֹּחַ מַעֲשָׂיו הִגִּיד לְעַמּוֹ **"The power of His works He told His people,** לָתֵת לָהֶם נַחֲלַת גּוֹיִם", **to give them the heritage of the nations"** – הַיְינוּ כִּי לְיִשְׂרָאֵל מִצַּדָּם **meaning that for Israel, on their own side,** מֵאֵין הַצּוֹרֶךְ לָהֶם **there is no need for them** לֵידַע שׁוּם חָכְמוֹת הַטֶּבַע, **to know any wisdom of nature;** כִּי עַל פִּי תּוֹרַת הֵם הַשֵּׁם **for by the Torah of Hashem** וְהִתְנַהֲגוּת הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ **and Hashem's conduct of the world** מִתְנַהֲגִים, **they conduct themselves,**[25] מִבְּלִי צוֹרֶךְ לָהֶם כְּלָל **with no need at all** לְהִתְנַהֲגוּת הַטִּבְעִיּוֹת, **for the ways of nature** – רַק מִי שֶׁאָמַר לַשֶּׁמֶן וְיַדְלִיק **only "He Who told the oil to burn** הוּא יֹאמַר לַחוֹמֶץ וְיַדְלִיק. **will tell the vinegar to burn" (Taanis 25a).**[26] הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ מֵאַהֲבָתוֹ אוֹתָם **Yet Hashem, out of His love for them,** רָצָה לְהוֹדִיעָם **wanted to let them know** גַּם חָכְמוֹת הַטֶּבַע, **the wisdoms of nature too,** וְזֹאת גַּם כֵּן נִמְצָא בְּהַתּוֹרָה, **and this too is found in the Torah,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁמָּצִינוּ **as we find in the Gemara (Pesachim 39b):** לֹא יִלְעוֹס אָדָם חִיטִּין בְּפֶסַח (פְּסָחִים לט:): בַּגְּמָרָא **"A person may not chew wheat on Pesach** לְהַנִּיחַ עַל גַּבֵּי מַכָּתוֹ, **to put on his wound"** – מִמֵּילָא נִשְׁמַע **from which we learn, in passing,** יָפָה לַמַּכָּה, אֲשֶׁר חִיטִּין לְעוּסִין **that chewed wheat is good for a wound;** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁמָּצִינוּ **and so we find** בְּכַמָּה מְקוֹמוֹת. **in several places.** – "כֹּחַ מַעֲשָׂיו וְלָזֶה **And so** הַיְינוּ הַתּוֹרָה – **that is, the Torah –** "הִגִּיד לְעַמּוֹ **"He told His people,**

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[25]The Ramban states the principle behind "Israel need no wisdom of nature" (Ramban, Shemos 13:16):

וּמִן הַנִּסִּים הַגְּדוֹלִים הַמְפוּרְסָמִים **From the great, famous miracles** אָדָם מוֹדֶה בַּנִּסִּים הַנִּסְתָּרִים, **a person comes to admit the hidden miracles,** שֶׁהֵם יְסוֹד הַתּוֹרָה כּוּלָּהּ; **which are the foundation of the whole Torah;** שֶׁאֵין לְאָדָם חֵלֶק בְּכָל דִּבְרֵי **for a person has no share** תּוֹרַת מֹשֶׁה רַבֵּינוּ **in the Torah of Moshe Rabbeinu** עַד שֶׁנַּאֲמִין **until we believe** וּמִקְרֵינוּ **of all our affairs and happenings** שֶׁכּוּלָּם נִסִּים; **that they are all miracles;** אֵין בָּהֶם טֶבַע **there is no "nature"** וּמִנְהָגוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם. **in them, nor "the way of the world."**

[26]Kometz HaMinchah 2:59 uses the same words of Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa for Avraham's way above nature, and sets the sorcery of the Bnei Kedem opposite it (see note to Part I). The Izhbitzer sets Yishmael's natural wisdom opposite the same principle. Together they place both families sent from Avraham's house against Israel's life above nature: the East with its sorcery, and Yishmael with his trust in nature.

לָתֵת לָהֶם נַחֲלַת גּוֹיִם", כִּי נַחֲלָתָם הוּא הַטֶּבַע, **to give them the heritage of the nations"; for their heritage is nature,** וְגַם זֹאת נִמְצָא בְּכֹחַ מַעֲשָׂיו **and this too is found in "the power of His works"** וְזֶהוּ "וְאֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדוֹת יִשְׁמָעֵאל… אֲשֶׁר הִגִּיד לְעַמּוֹ. **that He told His people. And this is "These are the generations of Yishmael… Sarah's maidservant, to Avraham":** כִּי עִיקַּר שִׁפְחַת שָׂרָה לְאַבְרָהָם": הוּא מִפְּנֵי שֶׁהָיְתָה שִׁפְחַת שָׂרָה, הַיִּחוּס שֶׁלּוֹ **for his main lineage is that she was Sarah's maidservant,** וּבִגְלַל זֶה נִמְצָא בָּהֶם חֲכָמִים. **and because of this there are wise men among them.** כִּי שְׁמוֹתָם מוֹרֶה עַל חָכְמָתָם: **For their names show their wisdom.** נְבָיוֹת מוֹרֶה **Nevayos teaches** שֶׁצָּרִיךְ מִלְּשׁוֹן נָבוּב; – **that his body is kept clean –** שֶׁיִּהְיֶה גּוּפּוֹ נָקִי, **that a person must see to it** הָאָדָם לִרְאוֹת וְאַדְבְּאֵל – הוּא גּוּף מְחוּמָם; **from the word navuv, hollow;** וְקֵדָר **and Kedar is a body kept warm; –** וּמִבְשָׂם **and Mivsam** הַיְינוּ לְבַל יֹאכַל לְשָׂבְעָה; **– that one should not eat to full satiety; –** **and Adbe'el** הַיְינוּ חַמְרֵי וְרֵיחָנֵי פָּקְחִין. **– "wine and fragrances make one sharp" (Yoma 76b).** זֹאת חָכְמָתָם בֵּין בְּעִנְיְנֵי בְּרִיאוּת הַגּוּף. **in matters of bodily health.** וְחָכְמָתָם הוּא **This is their wisdom** אָדָם לַחֲבֵירוֹ: הוּא וּמִשְׁמָע, וְדוּמָא וּמַשָּׂא **And their wisdom between man and his fellow is Mishma, Dumah and Massa:** הַיְינוּ לִשְׁמוֹעַ, וְלִשְׁתּוֹק, **to listen, to be silent,** וְלִסְבּוֹל. **and to bear with others.** וְעַל לְהַבָּא חָכְמָתָם: – חֲדַד **Chadad –** הַיְינוּ אִם תִּרְצֶה **if you** **want** לַעֲשׂוֹת דָּבָר חָדָשׁ, **to do something new (chadash),** – וְתֵימָא **and Teima –** וְכָל הָעוֹלָם **so that the whole world** יִתְפַּלְאוּ עַל זֶה; **will marvel (temah) at it;** – יְטוּר **Yetur –** הַיְינוּ תִּרְאֶה **see to it** שֶׁיִּהְיֶה מְסוּדָּר יָפֶה; **that it is well set in order (tur);** – נְפִישׁ **Nafish –** הַיְינוּ לִשְׁבּוֹת **to rest** וְלֵישֵׁב בְּדָבָר יָפֶה; **and settle well into the thing;** – וְקֶדְמָה **and Kedmah –** הַיְינוּ אִם תִּרְאֶה **if you see** שֶׁנָּכוֹן הוּא, **that it is right,** תַּקְדִּים לַעֲשׂוֹת, **be first (takdim) to do it,** פֶּן יְקַדְּמוּךָ. **lest others get ahead of you.** אַךְ עַל זֶה יָשִׁימוּ[27] כָּל חָכְמָתָם **But all their wisdom** הֵם רַק בְּעִנְיַן הַטֶּבַע, **is only in matters of nature,** וְעַל פְּנֵי כָל אֶחָיו נָפָל"; בִּטְחוֹנָם; וְלָכֵן כָּתוּב בּוֹ: **and so it is written of him: "Before all his brothers he fell," and in this they put their trust;** שֶׁיּוֹדְעִים שֶׁהַכֹּל מִן הַשָּׁמַיִם, הוּא **who know that everything is from Heaven,** כְּתִיב "יִשְׁכֹּון". **it is written "he shall dwell."**[28]

[וְזֶה דְּאִיתָא בַּגְּמָרָא **[And this is what the Gemara says** (בְּרָכוֹת נח.): **(Berachos 58a):** הָרוֹאֶה חַכְמֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אוֹמֵר: בָּרוּךְ שֶׁחָלַק מֵחָכְמָתוֹ לִירֵאָיו"; חַכְמֵי עוֹבְדֵי כּוֹכָבִים וּמַזָּלוֹת אוֹמֵר: בָּרוּךְ שֶׁנָּתַן מֵחָכְמָתוֹ לְבָשָׂר וָדָם". וְכֵן הוּא הַחִילּוּק בֵּין מַלְכֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל לְמַלְכֵי עוֹבְדֵי כּוֹכָבִים וּמַזָּלוֹת. וְהַיְינוּ **"Blessed is He Who apportioned (chalak) of His wisdom to those who fear Him"; on the sages of the nations he says: "Blessed is He Who gave (nasan) of His wisdom to flesh and blood."**[29] **The same difference holds between the kings of Israel and the kings of the nations.** וְהַיְינוּ

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[27]The Midrash, and the Maharal's reading of it, draw the same line between wisdom of nature and Torah (Eichah Rabbah 2:13):

אִם יֹאמַר לְךָ אָדָם: יֵשׁ חָכְמָה בַּגּוֹיִם – תַּאֲמֵן... יֵשׁ תּוֹרָה בַּגּוֹיִם – אַל תַּאֲמֵן. **If a person tells you, "There is wisdom among the nations" – believe it…; "There is Torah among the nations" – do not believe it.**

The Maharal explains (Netiv HaTorah 14):

כִּי אֵין חַכְמֵי הָאוּמּוֹת רְאוּיִים אֶל שֵׂכֶל הָאֱלֹקִי הַנִּבְדָּל, **For the sages of the nations are not fit for the separate, divine intellect,** שֶׁהוּא הַתּוֹרָה...; כִּי הָיוּ חֲכָמִים בָּעוֹלָם הַטִּבְעִי, **which is the Torah…; for they were wise in the natural world,** אֲבָל לְמַעְלָה מִן הַטֶּבַע... אֵין לִשְׁמוֹעַ לָהֶם. **but above nature… one is not to listen to them.**

[28]The Beis Yaakov brings this teaching of his father in Toldos 7:5; see Part VII.

[29]The Taz explains the difference between "chalak" and "nasan" in this berachah, and ties it to Avraham's gifts in our parsha (Taz, Orach Chaim 224:1):

מִפְּנֵי שֶׁיִּשְׂרָאֵל **This is because Israel** הֵם חֵלֶק מִמֶּנּוּ יִתְבָּרַךְ, **are a portion (chelek) of Him,** וְחָכְמַת עוֹבְדֵי כּוֹכָבִים וּמַזָּלוֹת **while the wisdom of the nations** הוּא חָכְמַת הַטֶּבַע **is the wisdom of nature** וְאֵין לָהּ שַׁיָּיכוּת לְהַקְדּוּשָׁה, **and has no connection to holiness;** כִּי חָכְמַת יִשְׂרָאֵל וְהִתְנַהֲגוּתָם **for the wisdom and conduct of Israel** הוּא עַל פִּי תּוֹרַת הַשֵּׁם. **are by the Torah of Hashem.** תַּשְׁלוּם.] **End of addendum.]**

> The Izhbitzer does not dismiss this wisdom. Hashem placed it in the Torah "out of His love," and Yishmael has it because his mother was Sarah's maidservant. The Beis Yaakov, the Izhbitzer's son, reads the same pasuk and the same words, "shifchas Sarah," as the measure of holiness in Yishmael.

Why Yishmael is called "son of Avraham"

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ל״ז · Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 37

וְאֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדוֹת יִשְׁמָעֵאל **"These are the generations of Yishmael,** בֶּן אַבְרָהָם וְגוֹמֵר. **son of Avraham,"** **and so on.** הָעִנְיָן **The point is** שֶׁיִּשְׁמָעֵאל נִקְרָא בֶּן אַבְרָהָם **that Yishmael is called Avraham's son** לְפִי שֶׁבְּלִידַת **that he fathered later,** שֶׁהוֹלִיד אַחַר כָּךְ, **more than the nations** יוֹתֵר מֵהָאוּמוֹת **because at Yishmael's birth** יִשְׁמָעֵאל שִׁפְחַת שָׂרָה עוֹד, **Hagar his mother** הָיְתָה הָגָר אִמּוֹ **Sarah's maidservant,** שֶׁלֹּא הָיָה אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ **when Avraham our father,** עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם **peace be upon him,** נִשְׁלַם עוֹד בְּכָל הַשְׁלֵימוּת; **had not yet reached full completion;** לָזֶה הָיָה בּוֹ **therefore there was in him** מְעַט קְדוּשָׁה. **a little holiness.** כִּי הָאָדָם קוֹדֶם הַשְׁלָמָתוֹ **For a person, before he is complete,** הוּא נִכְנָס לְכָל הַסְּפֵקוֹת **enters every uncertain venture** פֶּן יַרְוִיחַ מִזֶּה. **in case he may gain from it.** אֲבָל הַתּוֹלְדוֹת **But the offspring** שֶׁהוֹלִיד אַחַר זֶה, **that he fathered afterwards,** שֶׁמֵּתָה שָׂרָה **when Sarah had died** וְהָיָה נִשְׁלַם בְּכָל הַשְׁלֵימוּת **and he was fully complete** וְלֹא הָיָה צָרִיךְ **and no longer needed** – לְשׁוּם עֲבוֹדָה כְּלָל **any service at all** – … לָזֶה לֹא הָיָה **therefore there was not,** בְּאֵלֶּה הַתּוֹלְדוֹת **in these offspring,** שׁוּם קְדוּשָׁה **any holiness** וְכֹחַ בְּפָנִימִיּוּת. **or inner power.** וְלָזֶה גֵּרֵי מִגֵּרֵי שְׁאָר יִשְׁמָעֵאל **And so converts from Yishmael** הֵם גְּדוֹלִים בְּמַעֲלָה **are greater in standing** כִּדְאִיתָא בַּזּוֹהַר הַקָּדוֹשׁ **than converts from the other nations,** הָאוּמוֹת, **as the holy Zohar says** (יִתְרוֹ פז.). **(Yisro 87a).**[30]

> The Beis Yaakov and Pri Tzaddik weigh Keturah's sons differently, and the difference is instructive. The Beis Yaakov speaks of what was in them from birth: born after Avraham's completion, they had no inner holiness. Pri Tzaddik speaks of what Avraham gave them afterwards: a Name that keeps a root of holiness alive in them, even in impurity.

וְנִרְאֶה לִי עִיקָּר, **It seems to me the main point is** דְּבִישְׂרָאֵל יֵשׁ טַעַם, **that with Israel there is reason,** לְפִי שֶׁהֵם דְּבֵקִים בּוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ; **for they cleave to Him;** וְכָל שֶׁאַתָּה אוֹמֵר "חֵלֶק", **and whenever you say "apportioned,"** צָרִיךְ אַתָּה לָדַעַת **you must know** מִמִּי נֶחֱלַק...; **from whom it was apportioned…;** מַה שֶּׁאֵין כֵּן בָּאוּמוֹת, **not so with the nations,** שֶׁאֵין לָהֶם יִחוּס אַחֲרֵי הַנּוֹתֵן, **who have no tie back to the Giver,** כְּמוֹ כָּל מַתָּנָה **like any gift,** דְּלֵית בָּהּ אַחֲרָיוּת עַל הַנּוֹתֵן... **for which the giver bears no responsibility…** וְעַל כֵּן **And so,** – "וּלְבְנֵי הַפִּלַגְשִׁים... נָתַן אַבְרָהָם מַתָּנוֹת" **"to the sons of the concubines… Avraham gave gifts"** – פֵּירֵשׁ רַשִׁ"י: **Rashi explains,** – "שָׁם טוּמְאָה מָסַר לָהֶם" **"he handed them a name of impurity"** – הוּא גַּם כֵּן עַל הַכַּוָּנָה שֶׁזָּכַרְתִּי: **this too is in the sense I mentioned:** שֶׁאַחַר שֶׁנָּתַן לָהֶם מַתָּנָה זוֹ **that once he gave them this gift,** שׁוּב אֵין דְּבֵיקוּת בַּנּוֹתֵן. **there is no more attachment to the Giver.**

[30]Beis Yaakov 37 continues: all of Yishmael's life came from Avraham's plea וְלוּ יִשְׁמָעֵאל יִחְיֶה לְפָנֶיךָ and Hashem's answer וְלִישְׁמָעֵאל שְׁמַעְתִּיךָ (Bereishis 17:18–20). How much more so the son of the mistress, of whom Hashem said on His own, וְאֶת בְּרִיתִי אָקִים אֶת יִצְחָק , a covenant that stands forever.

VI. Wisdom Needs Attachment: “Before All His Brothers He Fell”

> Mei HaShiloach said that Yishmael fell because he trusted his wisdom of nature. The Beis Yaakov takes the next step: wisdom that is not attached to Hashem is worth nothing, however useful it is.

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות מ׳ · **Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 40:1**

עַל פְּנֵי כָל אֶחָיו נָפָל. **“Before all his brothers he fell.”** מִתְחִלָּה נֶאֱמַר "יִשְׁכֹּן" **First it says “he shall dwell,”** וְאַחַר זֶה נֶאֱמַר "נָפָל"; **and afterwards it says “he fell.”** הוּא כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ **This is as they said** בַּזוֹהַר הַקָּדוֹשׁ (יִתְרוֹ פו.): **in the holy Zohar (Yisro 86a):** – "וְהוּא יִהְיֶה פֶּרֶא אָדָם" **“He will be a wild man”** – פֶּרֶא אָדָם וְלֹא אָדָם. **“a wild man, and not a man.** פֶּרֶא אָדָם, **A wild man,** מְשׁוּם דְּאִתְגְּזַר **because he was circumcised,** וְשֵׁירוּתָא דְּאָדָם הֲוָה בֵּיהּ **and the beginning of a man was in him,** וְכוּלֵי **and so on;** וְלָא אִשְׁתְּלִים **but he was not completed** בְּפִקּוּדֵי אוֹרַיְיתָא. **by the mitzvos of the Torah.** אֲבָל זַרְעָא דְּיִשְׂרָאֵל **But the seed of Israel,** דְּאִשְׁתְּלִמוּ בְּכֹלָּא, **who were completed in everything,** אִקְרוּן אָדָם מַמָּשׁ. **are called truly ‘man.’”** וְהוּא שֶׁאַף שֶׁהָיָה בּוֹ חָכְמָה **That is: though he had the wisdom** שֶׁזֶּה מוֹעִיל לִרְווּחַ הַקּוֹדֶשׁ, **which helps** אֵיךְ לִשְׁמוֹר אֶת הַגּוּף, **of how to guard the body,** כִּדְאִיתָא בְּשִׁשָּׁה סְדָרִים (נְדָרִים לח.): **as the Talmud says (Nedarim 38a):** אֵין הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא **“The Holy One, blessed be He,** מַשְׁרֶה שְׁכִינָתוֹ **rests His Shechinah** אֶלָּא עַל **only on one who is wise, strong and wealthy”** – אָכֵן מִי שֶׁאֵינוֹ דָבוּק – חָכָם גִּבּוֹר וְעָשִׁיר **still, one who does not cleave** בָּהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ, **to Hashem** – אָזַי אֵין שׁוּם חֶשְׁבּוֹנוֹת **then there is no worth at all** בָּאֵלֶּה הַחָכְמוֹת. **in these wisdoms.**[31] לָזֶה כְּתִיב בֵּיהּ: **That is why it is written of him:** "עַל פְּנֵי כָל אֶחָיו נָפָל", **“Before all his brothers he fell”;** שֶׁהָעִיקָּר הוּא **for the main thing is** לִהְיוֹת דָבוּק בָּהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ. **to cleave to Hashem.** כִּי מִי שֶׁהוּא דָבוּק **For one who cleaves** בָּהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ, **to Hashem** – רוֹדְפִים אַחֲרָיו **there pursue him,** וּכְעִנְיָן דְּאִיתָא **as it says** בְּשִׁשָּׁה סְדָרִים (יוֹמָא יח.): **in the Talmud (Yoma 18a):** – "וְהַכֹּהֵן הַגָּדוֹל מֵאֶחָיו" **“The kohen who is greater than his brothers”** – גַּדְּלֵהוּ מִשֶּׁל אֶחָיו. **make him great from what is his brothers’.**

> Father and son read “nafal” the same way from two sides. For the Izhbitzer, Yishmael fell because he trusted nature. For the Beis Yaakov, the wisdom of the body is real, and even helps bring ruach hakodesh, but without attachment it has no weight. The one who cleaves to Hashem does not need to chase it; it comes to him.

VII. The Husk Before the Fruit

> If the wisdom outside the house is a husk, why did it come first? Yishmael had twelve princes before Yaakov had twelve tribes. Three passages answer from three sides.

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[31] The same Rabbi Chanina ben Dosa whose words on oil and vinegar the Izhbitzer quoted teaches (Avos 3:9):

כָּל שֶׁיִּרְאַת חֶטְאוֹ קוֹדֶמֶת לְחָכְמָתוֹ, **Whoever’s fear of sin comes before his wisdom,** חָכְמָתוֹ מִתְקַיֶּמֶת; **his wisdom endures;** וְכָל שֶׁחָכְמָתוֹ קוֹדֶמֶת לְיִרְאַת חֶטְאוֹ, **and whoever’s wisdom comes before his fear of sin,** אֵין חָכְמָתוֹ מִתְקַיֶּמֶת. **his wisdom does not endure.**

And the Ramchal, in mussar (Mesillas Yesharim, ch. 1):

וּכְשֶׁתִּסְתַּכֵּל בַּדָּבָר תִּרְאֶה כִּי הַשְׁלֵמוּת הָאֱמִתִּי הוּא **When you look into the matter, you will see that true completeness** כִּי רַק זֶה הוּא הַטּוֹב. **for only this is the good.** רַק הַדְּבֵקוּת בּוֹ יִתְבָּרַךְ... **is only cleaving to Him…,**

Twelve princes before twelve tribes

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ל״ט · Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 39

שְׁנֵים עָשָׂר נְשִׂיאִים לְאוּמֹתָם. **"Twelve princes for their nations."** הָעִנְיָן **The point is** דּוּגְמַת הַשְּׁנֵים עָשָׂר נְשִׂיאִים **that Yishmael had twelve princes** לְיִשְׁמָעֵאל **matching the twelve princes** שֶׁבַּקְּדוּשָּׁה, כִּי קְלִיפָּה קוֹדֶמֶת לַפְּרִי תָּמִיד. **of holiness; for the husk always comes before the fruit.**[32] לָזֶה הָיָה מִתְּחִלָּה **So there came first** שְׁנֵים עָשָׂר נְשִׂיאֵי יִשְׁמָעֵאל, **the twelve princes of Yishmael,** שֶׁהֵם הַקְּלִיפָּה, **who are the husk;** וְהוּא לְטוֹבַת הַפְּרִי, **and it is for the good of the fruit,** שֶׁיִּהְיֶה טוֹב לְיִשְׂרָאֵל; **so that it will be good for Israel.**[33] וְכֵן מִתְּחִלַּת הַבְּרִיאָה **So too from the beginning of creation** הֵכִין הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ **Hashem prepared** כָּל הַטּוֹבוֹת עֲבוּר הָאָדָם, **all the good things for man,** שֶׁיִּהְיֶה טוֹב לוֹ. **so that it would be good for him.**

The chaff carries the grain

קוֹמֶץ הַמִּנְחָה, ב׳:נ״ט · Kometz HaMinchah 2:59

דְּמָשְׁלוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה כְּשָׁפִים לְתֶבֶן, **For the Sages compared sorcery to straw,** וְכֵן הִמְשִׁיל הַכָּתוּב **and so the pasuk compares** נָגָד נְבוּאַת אֱמֶת: נְבוּאַת שֶׁקֶר **false prophecy to true prophecy:** מַה "לַתֶּבֶן אֶת הַבָּר" **"What is the straw to the grain?"** (יִרְמְיָה כג, כח). **(Yirmiyah 23:28).**[34] … וּכְמוֹ שֶׁהַתֶּבֶן **And just as the straw** נוֹשֵׂא הַבָּר **carries the grain** כָּל זְמַן הַגִּידּוּל, **all the while it grows,** כֵּן אֲבָל אַחַר שֶׁגָּדַל הַבָּר – … **But once the grain has grown,** הַתֶּבֶן נִזְרָק; **the straw is thrown away;** וְכֵן בְּהַשְׁלָמַת יִצְחָק **and so,** וּמִדָּתוֹ **when Yitzchak – and his attribute were complete –** אָז: **then:** …וַיֹּסֶף וְגוֹמֵר" **"And he again…** וַיְשַׁלְּחֵם". **and he sent them away."**

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[32]The Malbim reads the whole family of Avraham this way (Malbim, Bereishis 25:1):

וְהוֹצִיא גַּם כֵּן **He also brought forth** עָלִים וּקְלִיפּוֹת **leaves and shells** שֶׁיִּהְיוּ שׁוֹמְרִים לַפְּרִי; **to guard the fruit.** וְיֵשׁ קְלִיפָּה שֶׁבָּאָה לִפְנֵי הַפְּרִי, **There is a shell that comes before the fruit…,** וּבְעֵרֶךְ זֶה הָיָה יִשְׁמָעֵאל, **and of this kind was Yishmael,** הַקּוֹדֶמֶת לַפְּרִי... שֶׁנּוֹלַד קוֹדֶם יִצְחָק; **born before Yitzchak;** וְיֵשׁ קְלִיפָּה הַמְאוּחֶרֶת לַפְּרִי, **and there is a shell that comes after the fruit,** וּבְעֵרֶךְ זֶה הָיוּ בְּנֵי קְטוּרָה. **and of this kind were the sons of Keturah.**

That, he says, is why the pasuk says "vayosef": they were only an addition to the main thing.

[33]The Shelah adds that the shell itself holds on to holiness at its root (Shelah, Toldos, Torah Ohr 49):

הוּא כְּמוֹ קְדִימַת הַקְּלִיפָּה וְעִנְיַן יְצִיאַת הַקְּלִיפּוֹת **The coming out of the kelipos** מֵאֲבוֹת הַקְּדוֹשִׁים **from the holy Avos** בְּלֹא הַקְדָּמַת הַקְּלִיפָּה... שֶׁאִי אֶפְשָׁר לַפְּרִי, **is like the shell coming before the fruit; for there can be no fruit without the shell first…,** וְיַעֲקֹב הוּא הַפְּרִי. … כִּי הַקְּלִיפָּה יֵשׁ לָהּ אֲחִיזָה **and Yaakov is the fruit. For the shell has a hold** בַּקְּדוּשָּׁה בְּשָׁרְשָׁהּ... בְּהִתְפַּשְּׁטוּתָא, **in holiness at its root…,** וְהַטּוּמְאָה הִיא בְּהִתְפַּשְּׁטוּתָהּ **and the impurity is in its spreading out;** וְלָעֲתִיד תַּחֲזוֹר וְתִטָּהֵר עַל יְדֵי הַצַּדִּיקִים הַקְּדוֹשִׁים. **and in the future it will return and be purified through the holy tzaddikim.**

[34]Kometz HaMinchah assigns wisdom, prophecy and Torah to the three Avos: כִּי חָכְמָה – מֵאַבְרָהָם, **for wisdom comes from Avraham,** וּנְבוּאָה – מִיִּצְחָק **and prophecy from Yitzchak,** … (דִּכְתִיב בָּהּ "אֱמֶת") וְתוֹרָה **and Torah (of which "truth" is written)** – לְיַעֲקֹב. **belongs to Yaakov.**

The same souls, through the gate of Yaakov

בֵּית יַעֲקֹב, תּוֹלְדוֹת, אוֹת ז׳ · **Beis Yaakov, Toldos 7:5**

וּמִי הוּא שֶׁיָּכוֹל לְהַרְאוֹת **And who is able to show** שֶׁיֵּשׁ בְּכָל בְּרִיאָה **that in every creature there is** כְּבוֹד שָׁמַיִם, **the glory of Heaven,** אֲפִילוּ בְּהַדּוֹמֶם? **even in the inanimate?** וְזֶה הוּא יַעֲקֹב אָבִינוּ, **That is Yaakov our father,** שֶׁהוּא יָכוֹל **who is able to** "יַשְׁמִיעַ כָּל תְּהִלָּתוֹ"; **"declare all His praise."** שֶׁהַשְּׁנֵים עָשָׂר שְׁבָטִים שֶׁל יַעֲקֹב **For the twelve tribes of Yaakov** הָיוּ יוֹצְאִין מִתְּחִלָּה מִנָּחוֹר **were coming out at first from Nachor,** וְאַחַר כָּךְ מִיִּשְׁמָעֵאל, **and afterwards from Yishmael;** וְלֹא הָיָה רַק שֶׁל עוֹלָם הַיְינוּ בִּישׁוּב הַדַּעַת **that is, in the practical understanding but it was only below,** לְתַתָּא, **of this world,** הַזֶּה, כִּדְאִיתָא בְּמֵי הַשִּׁילֹחַ (חֵלֶק א, סוֹף פָּרָשַׁת חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, **as it says in Mei HaShiloach (Part I, end of Chayei Sarah,** דִּבּוּר הַמַּתְחִיל "וְאֵלֶּה") **s.v. "Ve'eileh"),** שֶׁזֶּה מוֹרִים הַשֵּׁמוֹת **that this is what the names** שֶׁל בְּנֵי יִשְׁמָעֵאל. **of Yishmael's sons show.** וְעַכְשָׁיו יוֹצְאִין **And now there come out** אֵלּוּ הַנְּפָשׁוֹת בָּעַצְמָן **these very same souls** עַל יְדֵי יַעֲקֹב אָבִינוּ **through Yaakov our father,** בִּשְׁנֵים עָשָׂר שְׁבָטִים, **in the twelve tribes;** וְאֵלּוּ הֵם לְעֵילָּא, **and these are above,** שֶׁהֵם מְלֵאִים דִּבְרֵי תּוֹרָה **for they are full of words of Torah** שֶׁהֵם קַיָּמִים **that endure** לְעוֹלְמֵי עוֹלָמִים; **forever and ever.** מוֹסִיף שֶׁבַח **It adds praise** עַל הָרִאשׁוֹנִים, **over the first ones,** שֶׁהֵם לֹא הָיוּ **who were nothing** רַק מָשָׁל וְדִמְיוֹן, **but a parable and likeness,** שֶׁהָיוּ צְרִיכִים לֵילֵךְ דֶּרֶךְ יַעֲקֹב; **who had to go by way of Yaakov.** כִּי אֲפִילוּ מִיִּשְׁמָעֵאל, **For even from Yishmael,** שֶׁהוּא חָבִיב מִכָּל הָאֻמּוֹת, **the dearest of all the nations,** אִם יִרְצֶה לְהִדָּבֵק **one who wants to cleave** בַּהַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ, **to Hashem** מוּכְרָח לֵילֵךְ דֶּרֶךְ יַעֲקֹב, **must go by way of Yaakov,** שֶׁיְּעוֹרֵר בּוֹ חַיִּים; **who will awaken life in him.** כִּי הַשֵּׁם יִתְבָּרַךְ הִבְטִיחַ **For Hashem promised** לְאַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם **Avraham our father, peace be upon him,** (בְּרֵאשִׁית כב, יז): **(Bereishis 22:17):** "וְיִרַשׁ זַרְעֲךָ אֵת שַׁעַר אֹיְבָיו", **"Your seed will inherit the gate of his enemies";** שֶׁעַל יָדוֹ יְכוֹלִים **and the gate is Yaakov,** וְהַשַּׁעַר הוּא יַעֲקֹב, **through whom one can** לִכָּנֵס לִקְדֻשָּׁה, **enter holiness;** וּבְלֹא דֶּרֶךְ יַעֲקֹב **and without the way of Yaakov** אֵין לָהֶם שַׁעַר כְּלָל; **they have no gate at all.** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁהֵם **As they are,** עוֹמְדִים בְּפְנֵי עַצְמָן, **standing on their own,** אַף שֶׁיִּרְצוּ **even if they want** לַעֲבוֹד אֶת הַשֵּׁם, **to serve Hashem,** לֹא יָאִיר לָהֶם **He will not shine for them,** רַק כְּשֶׁיִּכָּנְסוּ **only when they enter** דֶּרֶךְ יַעֲקֹב. **by way of Yaakov.** לָכֵן כְּתִיב "וְאֵלֶּה". **That is why it is written "Ve'eileh."**

> The three passages fit together. The husk comes first and protects the fruit (Beis Yaakov 39). The chaff carries the grain while it grows and is thrown away once Yitzchak is complete (Kometz HaMinchah). And what Yishmael's sons held "below," as wisdom for this world, comes out again in Yaakov's twelve tribes "above," full of Torah (Beis Yaakov, Toldos 7). Even for Yishmael, the way back into holiness is through Yaakov.

VIII. Yishmael's Teshuvah

> Yishmael's story does not end with "he fell." The Torah has already shown him at his father's burial, and it describes his death in words used for the righteous.

The pesukim

בְּרֵאשִׁית כה, ט; כה, יז · Bereishis 25:9, 25:17

וַיִּקְבְּרוּ אֹתוֹ **They buried him,** יִצְחָק וְיִשְׁמָעֵאל בָּנָיו **Yitzchak and Yishmael his sons,** אֶל מְעָרַת הַמַּכְפֵּלָה. **in the Cave of Machpelah.** … וְאֵלֶּה שְׁנֵי חַיֵּי יִשְׁמָעֵאל: **These are the years of Yishmael's life:** מְאַת שָׁנָה וּשְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה **a hundred and thirty years** וְשֶׁבַע שָׁנִים; **and seven years;** וַיִּגְוַע וַיָּמָת **he expired and died,** וַיֵּאָסֶף אֶל עַמָּיו. **and was gathered to his people.**

The Gemara: teshuvah in his father's lifetime

> The Gemara has said that a death described with both "expiring" and "being gathered" is the death of the righteous. It asks:

בָּבָא בַּתְרָא טז: · Bava Basra 16b

"גְּוִיעָה" וַ"אֲסִיפָה"! **of whom it is written** דִּכְתִיב בֵּיהּ וְהָא יִשְׁמָעֵאל, **But what about Yishmael, "expiring" and "being gathered"!** אַדְּהָכִי אִיתְּעַר בְּהוּ רָבָא, **Meanwhile Rava woke up** אֲמַר לְהוּ: **and said to them: Children,** דַּרְדְּקֵי, **this is what Rabbi Yochanan said:** הָכִי אָמַר רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן: **Yishmael did teshuvah** עָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה **in his father's lifetime,** בְּחַיֵּי אָבִיו, **as it says:** שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: "וַיִּקְבְּרוּ אֹתוֹ **"They buried him,** יִצְחָק וְיִשְׁמָעֵאל בָּנָיו". **Yitzchak and Yishmael his sons."**[35]

Pri Tzaddik: in Avraham's merit

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ח׳ · Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 8:1

וְשַׁיָּיכוּת הַפְּטָרָה זוֹ **The connection of this haftarah** לְפָרָשָׁה זוֹ **to this parsha** הוּא לֹא רַק **is not only** לְמַה שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר בָּהּ **to what is said in it,** "וְאַבְרָהָם זָקֵן בָּא בַּיָּמִים", **"And Avraham was old, advanced in days,"** שֶׁמְּדַבֶּרֶת מֵעִנְיָן זֶה **which speaks of this theme:** (שְׁלֵימוּת הַזִּקְנָה בְּכָל הַמַּדְרֵגוֹת): **(the completeness of old age at every level).**[36] … וְאַחַר כָּךְ **And then,** בְּסוֹף הַפָּרָשָׁה כְּתִיב: **at the end of the parsha, it is written:** "וְאֵלֶּה שְׁנֵי חַיֵּי יִשְׁמָעֵאל… **"These are the years of Yishmael's life…** וַיִּגְוַע וַיָּמָת **he expired and died,** – וַיֵּאָסֶף אֶל עַמָּיו" (כה, יז) **and was gathered to his people" (25:17) –** שֶׁזָּכָה גַּם כֵּן **for he too merited,** בִּשְׁבִיל אַבְרָהָם, **because of Avraham,**[37] שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר בּוֹ גְּוִיעָה וַאֲסִיפָה **that there is said of him "expiring" and "being gathered,"** כַּ

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[35]Rashi on Bereishis 25:9: מִכָּאן **From here [we learn]** שֶׁעָשָׂה יִשְׁמָעֵאל תְּשׁוּבָה **that Yishmael did teshuvah** וְהוֹלִיךְ אֶת יִצְחָק לְפָנָיו, **and let Yitzchak go ahead of him;** וְהִיא שֵׂיבָה טוֹבָה **and this is the "good old age"** שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר בְּאַבְרָהָם. **said of Avraham.**

[36]Pri Tzaddik counts the steps of ziknah through the parsha: Sarah's years, complete in all ten middos; Avraham, זָקֵן בָּא בַּיָּמִים ; Eliezer, זְקַן בֵּיתוֹ , who earned the title by serving the Avos; and Yishmael. Therefore the haftarah is וְהַמֶּלֶךְ דָּוִד זָקֵן בָּא בַּיָּמִים , ending יְחִי אֲדֹנִי הַמֶּלֶךְ דָּוִד לְעֹלָם .

[37]The Arvei Nachal (on "Hashem blessed Avraham bakol") says Avraham saw that his task was done, because Yishmael had returned (Arvei Nachal, Chayei Sarah):

וְכַאֲשֶׁר הִשְׂגִּיחַ **And when he looked** אוּלַי עֲדַיִן יְתַקֵּן בְּנֵי אָדָם **whether he still had to repair people** אֲשֶׁר הֵם פְּסוֹלֶת שֶׁלּוֹ, **who are his dross,** רָאָה שֶׁכְּבָר עָשָׂה יִשְׁמָעֵאל תְּשׁוּבָה. **he saw that Yishmael had already done teshuvah.** וְנוֹדָע **And it is known** כִּי כְּלַל זוֹהֲמַת מִצַּד יָמִין **that the whole dross of the right side** הוּא יִשְׁמָעֵאל, **is Yishmael,** הַכּוֹלֵל פְּרָטִים רַבִּים; **who includes many particulars;** וּבִרְאוֹתוֹ עָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה, **and seeing** יִשְׁמָעֵאל עַצְמוֹ **that Yishmael himself had done teshuvah,** הֲרֵי גָּמַר **he had finished** גַּם הָעִנְיָן הַזֶּה. **this task too.**

צַדִּיקִים, **like the righteous,** מִפְּנֵי שֶׁעָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה **because he did teshuvah** בְּחַיֵּי אַבְרָהָם, **in Avraham's lifetime,** (בָּבָא בַּתְרָא טז:). כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ **as they said (Bava Basra 16b).**

Divrei Soferim: the root of Avraham would not let him stay

> Divrei Soferim has just called Esav, Yitzchak's dross, the root of all actual sin. Yishmael, the dross of Avraham, is different:

דִּבְרֵי סוֹפְרִים, פֶּרֶק ל״ח · Divrei Soferim 38:12

כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה (שָׁם), **as the Sages said (there, Bava Basra 16b);** אֲבָל יִשְׁמָעֵאל עָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה, **But Yishmael did teshuvah,** מוֹעֶלֶת בַּגּוֹיִם **does not work for the nations,** אֶלָּא דְּאֵין תְּשׁוּבָה **except that teshuvah** דְּלֹא נִתְּנָה תְּשׁוּבָה **for teshuvah was given** אֶלָּא לְיִשְׂרָאֵל, **only to Israel,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתְבוּ קַדְמוֹנֵינוּ, **as our early authorities wrote,** וְאִיתָא נַמִּי בְּתַנְחוּמָא הַאֲזִינוּ; **and it is also found in Tanchuma, Haazinu.** אֶלָּא שֶׁמִּכָּל מָקוֹם, **Nevertheless:** אֵין לוֹ שַׁיָּכוּת מִצַּד שֶׁהוּא גּוֹי **as a gentile,** לְיִשְׂרָאֵל, **he has no connection to Israel,** וְרַק מִצַּד שֶׁהוּא הַפְּסֹלֶת דְּאַבְרָהָם; **only insofar as he is the dross of Avraham.**[38] וְאֶצֶל אַבְרָהָם **In Avraham** הוּא רַק בַּכֹּחַ, **it was only potential,** וְהַיְצִיאָה לְפֹעַל **and its coming into actuality** הוּא בְּיִשְׁמָעֵאל; **is in Yishmael;** כִּי מַה שֶּׁבָּאָב בַּכֹּחַ **for what is potential in the father** יוֹצֵא לְפֹעַל בַּבֵּן; **becomes actual in the son.** וְהַיְצִיאָה לְפֹעַל **And the coming into actuality** בִּפְסֹלֶת דְּאַבְרָהָם **of Avraham's dross** אֵינָהּ אֶלָּא בְּזֶרַע הַגּוֹיִם **is only in offspring among the nations,** שֶׁאֵין נִקְרָא זַרְעוֹ; **which is not called his seed.** וְעַל כֵּן **Therefore** גַּם בְּיִשְׁמָעֵאל עַצְמוֹ, **even in Yishmael himself,** מִצַּד כֹּחַ אַבְרָהָם שֶׁבּוֹ, **because of the power of Avraham in him,** לֹא הָיָה לוֹ כֹּחַ **he did not have the strength** לְהִשָּׁאֵר כָּךְ; **to stay that way;** וְסוֹף, **and in the end,** מִצַּד שֹׁרֶשׁ אַבְרָהָם שֶׁבּוֹ, **because of the root of Avraham in him,** עָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה; **he did teshuvah;**[39] אֶלָּא דְּלֹא

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[38] "Dross" is the scum and slag that separates out when silver or gold is melted down and refined, and is skimmed off and thrown away. The Hebrew is סִיגִים (sigim), as in Mishlei 25:4:

הָגֹו סִיגִים מִכָּסֶף, **Remove the dross from the silver,** וְיֵצֵא לַצֹּרֵף כֶּלִי. **and a vessel comes out for the smith.**

Divrei Soferim's own word is פְּסֹלֶת (p'soles), "refuse": what is left over and rejected once the good has been taken. The image matters for the argument. Dross comes out of the same ore as the precious metal and still carries something of it; that is why Yishmael, Avraham's dross, still has "the root of Avraham" in him. And dross is what must be removed for the vessel to be made: Yishmael and Keturah's sons were separated out so that Yitzchak and Yaakov could come out pure.

The Zohar uses the same image. Avraham is silver (chesed) and Yitzchak is gold (gevurah); their other sons are the dross of each (Zohar Chadash, Yisro):

יִשְׁמָעֵאל וּבְנֵי קְטוּרָה, דְּנָפֵיק מִנֵּיהּ **Yishmael and the sons of Keturah, from whom came** מַה דְּלֵית הָכִי בְּאַבְרָהָם, **which is not so with Avraham,** דְּאִינוּן סִיגֵי הַכֶּסֶף... **who are the dross of the silver…;** וְיִצְחָק, דְּנָפַק מִנֵּיהּ עֵשָׂו, **and Yitzchak, from whom came Esav,** סִיגֵי דַּהֲבָא. **the dross of the gold.** אֲבָל יַעֲקֹב **But Yaakov –** עַרְסֵיהּ שְׁלֵימָא אִיהוּ. **his bed was whole.**

Yaakov said the same of himself in the Gemara (Pesachim 56a):

שְׁמָא חַס וְשָׁלוֹם **Perhaps, Heaven forbid,** יֵשׁ בְּמִטָּתִי פְּסוּל, **there is a flaw in my bed,** כְּאַבְרָהָם שֶׁיָּצָא מִמֶּנּוּ יִשְׁמָעֵאל, **like Avraham, from whom came Yishmael,** וְאָבִי יִצְחָק **and my father Yitzchak,** שֶׁיָּצָא מִמֶּנּוּ עֵשָׂו. **from whom came Esav.**

[39] Takanas HaShavin 15:45 limits this to Yishmael himself (Takanas HaShavin 15:45):

וְרַק יִשְׁמָעֵאל עַצְמוֹ **And only Yishmael himself,** שֶׁנִּימּוֹל עַל יְדֵי אַבְרָהָם אָבִינוּ **who was circumcised by Avraham our father,** עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם, **peace be upon him,** – וּבִרְצוֹת הַשֵּׁם **with Hashem's favor –** זֶה שֶׁעָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה, **he is the one who did teshuvah,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה, **as the Sages said;** וְהוֹעִילָה לוֹ תְּפִלַּת אַבְרָהָם: **and there helped him**

הוֹעִילָה לוֹ **except that it did not help him** לְתַקֵּן הַקּוֹדֶם **to repair the past**, כְּבִישְׂרָאֵל **as it does in Israel,** דְּאַחַר הַתְּשׁוּבָה **where after teshuvah** אֵין מְצִיאוּת לַחֵטְא. **the sin no longer exists.**[40]

Pri Tzaddik: why Yishmael could return and Esav could not

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, מִשְׁפָּטִים, אות ד׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Mishpatim 4** *(abbreviations written out)*

כִּי יָדוּעַ **For it is known** שֶׁיֵּשׁ שְׁתֵּי קְלִיפּוֹת **that there are two kelipos,** שֶׁל יָמִין וּשְׂמֹאל **of right and left,** בְּ"זֶה לְעֻמַּת זֶה": **in "one opposite the other":** הַפְּסוֹלֶת שֶׁל חֶסֶד וּגְבוּרָה **the dross of chesed and gevurah** דִּקְדוּשָּׁה. **of holiness.** וְהֵם קְלִיפַּת יִשְׁמָעֵאל וְעֵשָׂו **These are the kelipos of Yishmael and Esav,** נֶגֶד שְׁנֵי הַפְּגָמִים **corresponding to the two flaws** הַנִּזְכָּרִים לְעֵיל. **mentioned above.**[41] יִשְׁמָעֵאל חֶסֶד שֶׁבַּקְלִיפָּה; **the chesed within the kelipah;** פְּגַם הַבְּרִית, **the flaw of the covenant,** הוּא תַּאֲוָה, **Yishmael is desire,** וְעֵשָׂו הוּא רְצִיחָה **and Esav is murder,** וְכַעַס וְלָשׁוֹן הָרָע. **anger and evil speech.** וְהַיְינוּ … **That is,** יֵשׁ לָהּ בֵּירוּר בִּקְדוּשָּׁה **can be refined** דִּקְלִיפַּת יִשְׁמָעֵאל **the kelipah of Yishmael** שֶׁעָשָׂה תְּשׁוּבָה **that he did teshuvah** וְלָכֵן נֶאֱמַר בּוֹ[42] **and therefore it is said of him** (כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב בְּבָבָא בַּתְרָא טז:). **(as stated in Bava Basra 16b).** אֲבָל קְלִיפַּת עֵשָׂו **But the kelipah of Esav** אֵין לָהּ תִּיקּוּן, **has no repair,** וְצָרִיךְ לְבַעֲרָהּ **and must be eradicated** מִכֹּל וָכֹל, **completely,** כְּמוֹ **as it says:** שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: "וְלֹא יִהְיֶה שָׂרִיד לְבֵית עֵשָׂו". **"There will be no survivor of the house of Esav."** וּלְטַעַם זֶה **For this reason** אֵין מְקַבְּלִים גֵּרִים מֵעַמָּלֵק **converts are not accepted from Amalek (** כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב בַּמְּכִילְתָּא, **as stated in the Mechilta,** סוֹף פָּרָשַׁת בְּשַׁלַּח). **end of Beshalach).**

> Three sources, one picture. Yishmael returned in Avraham's merit (Pri Tzaddik 8). He returned because the root of Avraham in him would not let him stay as he was, though his teshuvah could not erase the past as Israel's does (Divrei Soferim). And he could return at all because his side, desire, the chesed of the kelipah, can be refined into holiness, while Esav's cannot (Pri Tzaddik, Mishpatim).

IX. The Answer: Light That Comes Out of Darkness

> Now we can return to the question we began with: why does the Midrash call Yitzchak the small beginning, and the sons of Keturah the great increase?

Avraham's prayer, "לוּ יִשְׁמָעֵאל יִחְיֶה לְפָנֶיךָ" **"If only Yishmael would live (before You)"** – (בְּרֵאשִׁית יז, יח) **(Bereishis 17:18) –** עָלָיו לְבַד. **for him alone.**

[40]The Shem MiShmuel (Sochatchov) defines what Yishmael's teshuvah was (Shem MiShmuel, Shemos):

שֶׁמַּה שֶׁעָשָׂה יִשְׁמָעֵאל תְּשׁוּבָה **that Yishmael's "teshuvah"** לֹא תְּשׁוּבָה מַמָּשׁ, **was not full teshuvah,** אֶלָּא שֶׁהִכְנִיעַ אֶת עַצְמוֹ **but that he humbled himself** לִפְנֵי יִצְחָק, **before Yitzchak,** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב בְּקִבּוּרַת אַבְרָהָם: **as it says at Avraham's burial:** "יִצְחָק וְיִשְׁמָעֵאל בָּנָיו". **"Yitzchak and Yishmael his sons."** וּבַמִּדְרָשׁ כָּאן: **And the Midrash here:** בֶּן הָאָמָה **the maidservant's son** חוֹלֵק כָּבוֹד לְבֶן הַגְּבִירָה. **gives honor to the mistress's son.**

This fits Divrei Soferim here: his teshuvah was real, but it did not repair the past as Israel's teshuvah does.

[41]The two flaws Pri Tzaddik has been discussing are the flaw of the covenant of the flesh and the flaw of the covenant of the tongue. They are the two guards at the way to the Tree of Life: the keruvim and the flaming sword (Bereishis 3:24).

[42]The Lublin 1901 printing reads here יש לומר . The sense, and the parallel phrase a few lines earlier, בְּחִינָה זוֹ יֵשׁ לָהּ בֵּירוּר בִּקְדוּשָּׁה , indicate יֵשׁ לָהּ . In the same passage Pri Tzaddik brings the Zohar (Midrash HaNe'elam, I 138a): דְּאִלְמָלֵא חֶדְוָותָא דִּשְׁמַעְתָּא לָא לֵיהֱוֵי. **there would be no joy in learning.** Desire has a place in holiness. **were it not for the evil inclination,** יֵצֶר הָרַע,

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, חַיֵּי שָׂרָה, אות ו׳ · Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6:8

"וְהָיָה רֵאשִׁיתְךָ מִצְעָר" – **“though your beginning was small” –** עַל יִצְחָק אָבִינוּ עָלָיו הַשָּׁלוֹם; **of Yitzchak our father, peace be upon him;** – "וְאַחֲרִיתְךָ יִשְׂגֶּה מְאֹד" **“your latter end will greatly increase” –** עַל בְּנֵי קְטוּרָה: **of the sons of Keturah:** שֶׁמֵּהֶם יִשְׂרָאֵל מוֹצִיאִין **for from them Israel draws out,**[43] בָּאַחֲרוֹנָה (הָאוֹר הַיּוֹצֵא מִתּוֹךְ הַחֹשֶׁךְ) **in the end, all the depth of the Oral Torah** כָּל עוֹמֶק תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **(the light that comes out of the darkness),**[44] וּכְמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב: **as it is written:** "וַתֵּרֶב חָכְמַת שְׁלֹמֹה מֵחָכְמַת כָּל בְּנֵי קֶדֶם" **“Shlomo’s wisdom excelled the wisdom of all the Bnei Kedem,”** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁאָמַרְנוּ! **as we have said!** וְזֶהוּ שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: **And this is why it says** – "יִשְׂגֶּה מְאֹד" **“will greatly (me’od) increase” –** עַל דֶּרֶךְ מַה שֶּׁנֶּאֱמַר: **in the manner of what is said:** "וַיַּרְא אֱלֹהִים אֶת כָּל אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה **“God saw all that He had made,** וְהִנֵּה טוֹב מְאֹד" **and behold, it was very (me’od) good”** (בְּרֵאשִׁית א, לא), **(Bereishis 1:31),** שֶׁנִּדְרָשׁ **which is expounded** (בְּבְרֵאשִׁית רַבָּה פָּרָשָׁה ט) **(Bereishis Rabbah 9)** עַל כָּל הַהֵיפֶךְ מֵהַטּוֹב שֶׁיִּהְיֶה נֶהְפָּךְ **of everything opposed to the good that will be turned** לְ"טוֹב מְאֹד", **into “very good,”**[45] וְעַל דֶּרֶךְ מַה שֶּׁכָּתוּב **and in the manner of what is written** (בַּזֹּהַר הַקָּדוֹשׁ חֵלֶק ב קפד עַמּוּד א): **(in the holy Zohar II 184a):** "דְּלֵית נְהוֹרָא **“There is no light** אֶלָּא הַהוּא **except that** דְּנָפִיק מִגּוֹ חֲשׁוֹכָא, **which comes out of darkness,** וְלֵית טוֹב **and there is no good** אֶלָּא הַהוּא **except that** דְּנָפִיק מִגּוֹ בִּישָׁא"; **which comes out of evil.”** שֶׁמִּמָּזֶּה דַּוְקָא **For precisely from this** נַעֲשָׂה "טוֹב מְאֹד", **comes “very good,”**[46] וְזֶהוּ שֶׁאָמַר: **and that is what it says:** "וַאֲחֲרִיתְךָ יִשְׂגֶּה מְאֹד".

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[43]Pri Tzaddik’s promise can be seen in our own time (this, too, is an application). Rabbi Aryeh Kaplan begins Jewish Meditation by noting that “many American Jews have become involved in Eastern religions,” many of them unaware that Judaism has a meditative tradition of its own. In that book and in Meditation and the Bible he drew it out of the Torah itself. Yitzchak “went out lasuach in the field” (Bereishis 24:63), and the Gemara reads it as prayer (Berachos 26b):

יִצְחָק תִּקֵּן תְּפִלַּת מִנְחָה, **Yitzchak instituted the Minchah prayer,** שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: **as it says:** "וַיֵּצֵא יִצְחָק לָשׂוּחַ בַּשָּׂדֶה לִפְנוֹת עָרֶב"; **“Yitzchak went out lasuach in the field toward evening”;** וְאֵין "שִׂיחָה" אֶלָּא תְּפִלָּה. **and “sichah” means only prayer.**

And the early chassidim of the Mishnah (Berachos 5:1):

חֲסִידִים הָרִאשׁוֹנִים הָיוּ שׁוֹהִים שָׁעָה אַחַת **The early pious ones would wait one hour** וּמִתְפַּלְּלִים, **and then pray,** כְּדֵי שֶׁיְּכַוְּנוּ אֶת לִבָּם לַמָּקוֹם. **so as to direct their hearts to the Omnipresent.**

In Pri Tzaddik’s terms, this is the Oral Torah drawn back out of the East: what Jews went looking for among the Bnei Kedem turns out to be Yitzchak’s own, the very “coal of Yitzchak” that Avraham kept his other sons away from (Part III). The Me’or Einayim says the same of Yaakov, who went “to the land of the Bnei Kedem” to lift those sparks back to their root.

[44]Rav Tzadok uses the same pair of images elsewhere (Yisrael Kedoshim 10:26):

נִתְגַּלָּה עוֹמֶק הַחָכְמָה, **the depth of wisdom was revealed,** כִּקְלִיפָּה הַקּוֹדֶמֶת לַפְּרִי **like the shell that comes before the fruit,** וּבְרִישָׁא חֲשׁוֹכָא. **and out of the folly and “first comes darkness.”** וּמִתּוֹךְ הַשְּׁטוּת

[45]Bereishis Rabbah 9:7: “very good” includes the yetzer hara, for without it a person would not build a house, marry or have children.

[46]In chassidus this is the heart of the avodah. The Berditchever (Kedushas Levi, Bereishis):

אַךְ הִנֵּה עַל יְדֵי עֲבוֹדַת הַצַּדִּיקִים **But through the service of the tzaddikim** בְּתוֹרָה וּמִצְוֹת **in Torah and mitzvos** מְהַפְּכִין הַנִּיצוֹצוֹת **they turn the sparks** מֵחֲשֹׁכָא לִנְהוֹרָא, **from darkness to light,** וְעוֹלִין לְמַעְלָה מַעְלָה **and they rise higher and higher;** לְשָׁרְשָׁן וּמְקוֹרָם **to their root and source;** וְכַאֲשֶׁר נִתְעַלּוּ לְמַעְלָה, **and when they have risen above,** נִתּוֹסַף אוֹרָם **their light is increased,** כְּיִתְרוֹן הָאוֹר מִתּוֹךְ הַחֹשֶׁךְ, **like the advantage of light out of darkness,** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁאָמְרוּ (בְּרָכוֹת

“your latter end will greatly increase.” וּפָסוּק **And the pasuk** …וַיַּרְא אֱלֹהִים **“God saw…** וְהִנֵּה טוֹב מְאֹד" **and behold, it was very good”** ,נֶאֱמַר בְּסוֹף יוֹם שִׁשִּׁי **was said at the end of the sixth day,** בִּזְמַן תּוֹסֶפֶת שַׁבָּת; **at the time of the addition of Shabbos;** שֶׁבְּשַׁבָּת הוּא הַזְּמַן **for Shabbos is the time** לִזְכּוֹת לְהַתּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה, **to merit the Oral Torah,** שֶׁהוּא ה"רֹב חָכְמָה **which is the “much wisdom”** לְתַקֵּן ה"רֹב כַּעַס" **that repairs the “much vexation,”** ,שֶׁיִּהְיֶה "טוֹב מְאֹד" **so that it becomes “very good,”** וּכְמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב **as it is written** :(זֹהַר חֵלֶק א מז עַמּוּד ב) **(Zohar I 47b):** – "בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי" **“‘On the seventh day’ –** ,דְּאִיהוּ יוֹם שְׁבִיעִי **this is the Oral Torah,** דָּא תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **which is the seventh day,”** וְכוּלֵי; **and so on;** – וְהַיְינוּ מַלְכוּת פֶּה **that is, Malchus, the mouth –** תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה. **the Oral Torah.**

X. Out of the East, in Later Generations

> Pri Tzaddik said that from the sons of Keturah “Israel draws out, in the end, all the depth of the Oral Torah.” The end did not come all at once. Israel was sent back to the East, to Bavel, and later spread through all the lands of Yishmael; and out of those lands, generation after generation, came Torah that shone brighter for the darkness around it. First the sources that explain why, and then the people.

Why Bavel: back to Avraham’s house

פְּסָחִים פז: · **Pesachim 87b**

And Rabbi Elazar said: וְאָמַר רַבִּי אֶלְעָזָר: **The Holy One, blessed be He,** לֹא הִגְלָה הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא **exiled Israel to Bavel** אֶת יִשְׂרָאֵל לְבָבֶל **only because it is deep as She’ol,** אֶלָּא מִפְּנֵי שֶׁעֲמוּקָה כִּשְׁאוֹל: שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר **as it says:** "מִיַּד שְׁאוֹל אֶפְדֵּם **“From the hand of She’ol I will ransom them,** מִמָּוֶת אֶגְאָלֵם". **from death I will redeem them.”** רַבִּי חֲנִינָא אָמַר: **Rabbi Chanina said:** מִפְּנֵי שֶׁקָּרוֹב לְלָשׁוֹן תּוֹרָה. **Because their language is close to the language of Torah.** רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן אָמַר: **Rabbi Yochanan said:** מִפְּנֵי שֶׁשִּׁיגְּרָן לְבֵית אִמָּן. **Because He sent them back to their mother’s house.**[47] מָשָׁל

“In the place where baalei teshuvah stand…” בְּמָקוֹם שֶׁבַּעֲלֵי תְּשׁוּבָה עוֹמְדִין... **as the Sages said (Berachos 34b):** :לד)

And the Tanya names it the first of two kinds of nachas ruach above (Tanya, ch. 27):

from the complete nullifying of the sitra achra, מִבִּיטּוּל הַסִּטְרָא אַחֲרָא לְמִתְקָא **and its turning from bitter to sweet** ,וּמֵחֲשׁוֹכָא לִנְהוֹרָא **and from darkness to light,** .עַל יְדֵי הַצַּדִּיקִים **through the tzaddikim.**

[47] Rashi there (Rashi, Pesachim 87b):

“To their mother’s house”: – לְבֵית אִמָּן. **Avraham came out of Ur Kasdim.** אַבְרָהָם מֵאוּר כַּשְׂדִּים יָצָא.

Avraham is the first one drawn out of the East. The Gemara reads I Melachim 5:11, the very next pasuk after “Shlomo’s wisdom excelled the wisdom of all the Bnei Kedem,” as speaking of him (Bava Basra 15a):

“Eisan the Ezrachi” – זֶה הוּא אַבְרָהָם – **this is Avraham:** ,"אֵיתָן הָאֶזְרָחִי" :כְּתִיב הָכָא **here it is written “Eisan the Ezrachi,”** :וּכְתִיב הָתָם **and there it is written,** ."מִי הֵעִיר מִמִּזְרָח צֶדֶק" **“Who awakened righteousness from the East?”**

Rav Tzadok, in the section of Divrei Soferim right after the one quoted in Part VIII, calls Avraham “the first of the converts,” whose whole effort was to remove the impurity he came from; and yet (Divrei Soferim 38:13):

the name “the Ezrachi,” לְשֵׁם "הָאֶזְרָחִי", **he alone merited** וְרַק הוּא זָכָה **as though he were a native of Israel** .מִלֵּידָה **from birth.** כְּאִלּוּ הוּא אֶזְרָח בְּיִשְׂרָאֵל

The man from the mizrach, the East, became an ezrach, a native. Both words come from the same root, זרח , “to shine.”

לְאָדָם **It is like a man** – שֶׁכָּעַס עַל אִשְׁתּוֹ **who was angry with his wife:** ?לְהֵיכָן מְשַׁגְּרָהּ **where does he send her?** .לְבֵית אִמָּהּ **To her mother's house.**

> Bavel is Avraham's house, the East he came out of. Rabbi Elazar adds why the exile went there: it is "deep as She'ol," and from that depth Hashem redeems. Rav Tzadok explains what that depth produced.

The Talmud of Bavel: light out of the dark

סַנְהֶדְרִין כד. · **Sanhedrin 24a**

מַאי בָּבֶל? **What is "Bavel"?** אָמַר רַבִּי יוֹחָנָן: **Rabbi Yochanan said:** בְּלוּלָה בַּמִּקְרָא, **mixed (belulah) with Scripture,** בְּלוּלָה בַּמִּשְׁנָה, **mixed with Mishnah,** בְּלוּלָה בַּתַּלְמוּד. **mixed with Talmud.** אָמַר רַבִּי – **"He has set me in dark places** "בְּמַחֲשַׁכִּים הוֹשִׁיבַנִי כְּמֵתֵי עוֹלָם" **like those long dead"** – יִרְמְיָה: **Rabbi Yirmiyah said:** זֶה תַּלְמוּדָהּ שֶׁל בָּבֶל. **this is the Talmud of Bavel.**

פּוֹקֵד עֲקָרִים, אוֹת ו׳ · **Poked Akarim 6:4**

וְכֵן אִיתָא בְּסַנְהֶדְרִין (כ״ד עמוד א׳) **And in Sanhedrin (24a),** עַל פָּסוּק: **on the verse** "בְּמַחֲשַׁכִּים הוֹשִׁיבַנִי" – **"He has set me in dark places":** זוֹ תַּלְמוּדָהּ שֶׁל בָּבֶל, **this is the Babylonian Talmud,** שֶׁשָּׁם הָיָה הִתְגַּלּוּת עֹמֶק הַפִּלְפּוּל. **where there was revealed the depth of analytical debate.** וְהָאוֹר שֶׁמִּתּוֹךְ … דְּבָרָה זֶה גָּרַם גַּם כֵּן גָּלוּת בָּבֶל… **And this too was brought about by … the exile of Bavel…** שֶׁיּוּכַל לְהָאִיר הוּא אוֹר גָּדוֹל יוֹתֵר, **And the light that comes out of darkness is a greater light,** חָכְמַת תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה וְעַל כֵּן **Therefore** גַּם בְּתוֹךְ הַחֹשֶׁךְ. **even within the darkness.** הוּא דַּוְקָא **the wisdom of the Oral Torah** בִּכְלִי מְכֹעָר יוֹתֵר; **resides specifically in an uglier vessel;** דְּכְפִי תֹּקֶף הַחֹשֶׁךְ יוֹתֵר, כֵּן הוּא מֵאִיר יוֹתֵר. **for in proportion to the intensity of the darkness, so does it shine brighter.**

> This is the rule behind the whole part. The stronger the darkness of a place, the greater the light that can be drawn out of it, and the Oral Torah in particular grows in the "uglier vessel." Pri Tzaddik applies it to Bavel first, and then to all the other lands of exile.

Pri Tzaddik: "Many daughters have done valiantly"

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, תַּזְרִיעַ, אוֹת ח׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Tazria 8** *(abbreviations written out)*

אַף מָצִינוּ (מְנָחוֹת קי:) **But we find (Menachos 110a):**[48] – "בָּנַי מֵרָחוֹק" **"My sons from afar"** – אֵלּוּ גָּלְיוֹת שֶׁל בָּבֶל, **these are the exiles of Bavel,** שֶׁדַּעְתָּן מְיוּשֶׁבֶת עֲלֵיהֶן כְּבָנִים; **whose minds are settled, like sons;** – "וּבְנוֹתַי מִקְצֵה הָאָרֶץ" **"and My daughters from the end of the earth"** – אֵלּוּ גָּלְיוֹת שֶׁל

[48]The printed text reads Menachos 110b; the passage is on 110a. Pri Tzaddik also notes there (from Tanchuma, Noach 3) that the two yeshivos of Bavel never saw captivity or forced conversion. The same daf goes on to count Torah scholars in every place, east and west (Menachos 110a):

"מִמִּזְרַח שֶׁמֶשׁ וְעַד מְבוֹאוֹ **"From the rising of the sun to its setting** גָּדוֹל שְׁמִי בַּגּוֹיִם, **My Name is great among the nations,** וּבְכָל מָקוֹם **and in every place** "...מֻקְטָר מֻגָּשׁ לִשְׁמִי **incense is offered to My Name…" (Malachi 1:11).**

אָמַר רַבִּי יוֹנָתָן: **Rabbi Shmuel bar Nachmani said** אָמַר רַבִּי שְׁמוּאֵל בַּר נַחְמָנִי **in the name of Rabbi Yonasan:** אֵלּוּ תַּלְמִידֵי חֲכָמִים הָעוֹסְקִים בַּתּוֹרָה בְּכָל מָקוֹם; **These are the Torah scholars who study Torah in every place;** מַעֲלֶה אֲנִי כְּאִילּוּ מַקְטִירִין וּמַגִּישִׁין לִשְׁמִי. עֲלֵיהֶן **I account it to them as if they offered incense to My Name.**

שֶׁאֵין דַּעְתָּן מְיוּשֶׁבֶת עֲלֵיהֶן **these are the exiles of the other lands, whose minds are not** שֶׁאַר אַרְצוֹת, **settled,** כְּבָנוֹת. **like daughters.** … וְיִתָּכֵן לְפָרֵשׁ **It may be explained** לְשׁוֹן "שֶׁדַּעְתָּן מְיוּשֶׁבֶת" **that** דְּעִקַּר הִתְפַּשְׁטוּת **for** עַל הַתּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה… **refers to the Oral Torah…;** **the main spreading** תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה בְּבָבֶל, **of the Oral Torah was in Bavel,** כְּמוֹ שֶׁכָּתוּב (סֻכָּה כ.): **as it says (Sukkah 20a):** "עָלָה עֶזְרָא מִבָּבֶל וְיִסְּדָהּ… **"Ezra came up from Bavel and established it…;** הִלֵּל הַבַּבְלִי וְיִסְּדָהּ"; **Hillel the Babylonian established it";** (סַנְהֶדְרִין כד.): **and in the** וּבַגְּמָרָא **Gemara (Sanhedrin 24a):** – בְּמַחֲשַׁכִּים הוֹשִׁיבַנִי" **"He has set me in dark places"** – זֶה תַּלְמוּדָהּ שֶׁל בָּבֶל". **this is the Talmud of Bavel.** וְהַיְינוּ דְּשָׁם **That is: there was** עִקַּר הִתְפַּשְׁטוּת **the main spreading** תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה, **of the Oral Torah,** לְהוֹצִיא הָאוֹר **to bring the light out** מִתּוֹךְ הַחֹשֶׁךְ **of the darkness** עַל יְדֵי פִּלְפּוּלָהּ שֶׁל תּוֹרָה. **through the keen debate of Torah.** (תַּנְחוּמָא שָׁם): וּבְמִדְרָשׁ **And in the Midrash (Tanchuma, Noach 3):** הָעָם הַהֹלְכִים בַּחֹשֶׁךְ" **"The people who walk in darkness** – רָאוּ אוֹר גָּדוֹל" **have seen a great light"** – אוֹר שֶׁנִּבְרָא בַּיּוֹם רִאשׁוֹן, **the light created on the first day,** שֶׁגְּנָזוֹ הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא **which the Holy One hid away** לַעֲמֵלֵי תוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה; **for those who toil in the Oral Torah;** וְהַיְינוּ עַל תַּלְמוּד בַּבְלִי. **and this means the Talmud Bavli.** … וְזֶה שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר: **And this is what the pasuk says:** – רַבּוֹת בָּנוֹת עָשׂוּ חָיִל" **"Many daughters have done valiantly"** – שֶׁאֵין תַּלְמוּדִים שֶׁל גָּלְיוֹת **the learning of the exiles** שֶׁאַר אַרְצוֹת, **of the other lands,** מְיוּשֶׁבֶת עֲלֵיהֶם כְּבָנוֹת – דַּעְתָּן בַּתּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **whose minds are not settled in the Oral Torah as with daughters** – עָשׂוּ חַיִל בַּתּוֹרָה. **"did valiantly" in Torah.**

> Pri Tzaddik gives the theory both of its parts. Bavel, the East, is the main home of the Oral Torah, drawn out of the darkness. And the "daughters," the exiles of all the other lands, also "did valiantly."

Rav Tzadok: the wisdom held inside the kelipah

רְסִיסֵי לַיְלָה, סִימָן מ״ו · **Resisei Layla 46:2**

הַיְנוּ כַּנּוֹדָע **This is connected to the well-known tradition** דְּרַבִּי עֲקִיבָא, **that Rabbi Akiva,** שֶׁהוּא יְסוֹד הוּא מִבְּנֵי בָנָיו שֶׁל סִיסְרָא, **as is known,** כַּיָּדוּעַ, **the foundation of the Oral Torah,** תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **descended from Sisera** (סַנְהֶדְרִין צו:, לְגִרְסַת עֵין יַעֲקֹב). **(Sanhedrin 96b, in the Ein Yaakov version).** וּמִסְתַּמָּא הָיָה כֹּחַ זֶה בְּסִיסְרָא, **It follows that this power was in Sisera,** שֶׁאָז הָיְתָה כָּל הַחָכְמָה **for at that time all the wisdom** דְּחָכְמֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל **destined for Israel's sages** לַחוּץ **was still outside,** אֲצֶל אוֹתוֹ רָשָׁע. **enclosed within that wicked man.** … דְּאָז הָיְתָה הַתְחָלַת הִתְגַּלּוּת **At that time there began to be revealed** יְסוֹד תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה, **the foundation of the Oral Torah in this world,** בִּקְלִפָּה גְּרוּעָה דְּסִיסְרָא **wrapped in the coarse** הַמַּקִּיפָתוֹ. **degraded husk of Sisera that surrounded it.**

> The greatest of the Oral Torah was first "outside," wrapped in a husk, and had to be drawn out of it. Pri Tzaddik traces the same Rabbi Akiva back to Keturah's own family.

From Midian to Rabbi Akiva

פְּרִי צַדִּיק, יִתְרוֹ, אוֹת א׳ · **Pri Tzaddik, Yisro 1:2** *(abbreviations written out)*

שֶׁהָיָה בֶּן גֵּרִים… **For Rabbi Akiva** דְּרַבִּי עֲקִיבָא, **is the root of the Oral Torah,** שֹׁרֶשׁ תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **and he was a son of converts…** וּמִטַּעַם זֶה **For this reason** נִכְתַּב גַּם כֵּן מַתַּן תּוֹרָה **the giving of the Torah was written** בְּפָרָשַׁת יִתְרוֹ, **in Parshas Yisro,** וּפָרָשַׁת הַגֵּר **the parsha of the convert,** שֶׁהוּא

מֵעִנְיַן תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה... **which belongs to the Oral Torah…** :(גִּיטִּין נז) וְאִיתָא בַּגְּמָרָא **And the Gemara says (Gittin 57b):** מִבְּנֵי בָּנָיו שֶׁל סִיסְרָא **“Of the descendants of Sisera,** לְמָדוּ תִּינוֹקוֹת לְרַבִּנוּ **some taught children in Jerusalem”;** וּבְסֵפֶר הַמַּפְתֵּחַ **and in Sefer HaMafte’ach** בִּירוּשָׁלַיִם; נְסִים גָּאוֹן **of Rabbeinu Nissim Gaon** :הוּבָא הַגִּרְסָא **the reading is brought:** "וּמַאן אִינּוּן? רַבִּי עֲקִיבָא". **“And who are they? Rabbi Akiva.”** וְאִיתָא בְּסֵפֶר עֲשָׂרָה מַאֲמָרוֹת **And it says in Asarah Maamaros** לְרַבִּי מְנַחֵם עֲזַרְיָה **of Rabbi Menachem Azariah [of Fano]** שֶׁרַבִּי עֲקִיבָא בָּא מִסִּיסְרָא, **that Rabbi Akiva came from Sisera,** אֵשֶׁת חֶבֶר הַקֵּינִי, **wife of Chever the Kenite;** שֶׁבָּא עַל יָעֵל **who came upon Yael,** וְהִיא בָּאָה מִיִּתְרוֹ. **and she came from Yisro.**[49] … וּבְנֵי קֵינִי הָלְכוּ לְיַעְבֵּץ **And the Kenites went to Yaabetz …** לִלְמוֹד תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה **to learn the Oral Torah…,** וּמִבְּנֵי קֵינִי **and of the Kenites,** זָכוּ לֵישֵׁב בְּלִשְׁכַּת הַגָּזִית, **some merited to sit in the Chamber of Hewn Stone,** וּמִשָּׁם שֹׁרֶשׁ תּוֹרָה שֶׁבְּעַל פֶּה. **and from there is the root of the Oral Torah.**

> Yisro was the priest of Midian, and Midian was a son of Keturah. Pri Tzaddik’s promise in Chayei Sarah, that Israel would draw the sparks of the Oral Torah out of Keturah’s sons, is fulfilled in Yisro’s family: the Kenites on the Sanhedrin and, by this tradition, Rabbi Akiva himself. The same pattern continued in every later generation. What follows is our application of these sources to Jewish history; Rav Tzadok does not name these people.

Bavel: Baghdad

The land Avraham came out of, and where the Talmud was made, went on giving. In nineteenth-century Baghdad, Chacham Abdallah Somech taught a generation of scholars, and his student **Rabbi Yosef Chaim, the Ben Ish Chai** (1835–1909), became the master of halachah and kabbalah for all of Sephardi Jewry.[50] From his circle came **Rabbi Yaakov Chaim Sofer**, author of the Kaf HaChaim, born in Baghdad in 1870, and the kabbalist **Rabbi Yehuda Fatiyah** (1859–1942), the authority of his day on spirits and gilgulim, whose Minchas Yehuda draws on his encounters with them: the work of drawing souls out of the kelipah in its most literal form.[51] In the twentieth century Baghdad’s sons led Torah in Jerusalem: the kabbalists **Rabbi Salman Mutzafi** (1900–1974) and **Rabbi Yitzchak Kaduri** (c. 1898–2006), and **Rabbi Ovadia Yosef** (1920–2013), born in Baghdad and brought to Jerusalem as a child, who restored the honor of Sephardi halachah in our generation.[52]

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[49]Yisro is “the priest of Midian” (Shemos 2:16; 18:1), and Midian is a son of Keturah (Bereishis 25:2). The Kenites are Yisro’s descendants: “the sons of the Keini, Moshe’s father-in-law” (Shoftim 1:16), and Yael was “the wife of Chever the Keini” (Shoftim 4:17). Rav Tzadok makes the same connection in Resisei Layla 46:2, where Rabbi Akiva’s power was first “outside,” in Sisera; Sisera himself came from Chatzor, not the East, but the principle is the same.

[50]Rabbi Yosef Chaim of Baghdad (1835–1909), known by his work Ben Ish Chai, which joins kabbalah with practical halachah and is standard in Sephardi homes; also Ben Yehoyada on the aggados of the Talmud and the responsa Rav Pe’alim. His main teacher was Chacham Abdallah Somech (1813–1889). See Wikipedia: Yosef Hayyim.

[51]Rabbi Yaakov Chaim Sofer (Baghdad 1870 – Jerusalem 1939), a student of Chacham Abdallah Somech and the Ben Ish Chai, settled in Jerusalem and wrote the Kaf HaChaim (Wikipedia). Rabbi Yehuda Fatiyah (Baghdad 1859 – Jerusalem 1942), the leading student of the Ben Ish Chai, wrote Beis Lechem Yehuda on the Etz Chaim and Minchas Yehuda, and was the recognized authority on amulets, gilgulim and spirits (Wikipedia).

[52]Rabbi Salman Mutzafi (Baghdad 1900 – Jerusalem 1974) learned under Rabbi Yehuda Fatiyah at Midrash Zilkha and founded a yeshiva for Zohar and kabbalah near Kever Rachel (Daily Zohar). Rabbi Yitzchak Kaduri (Baghdad c. 1898 – Jerusalem 2006) learned with the Ben Ish Chai, Rabbi Fatiyah, the Kaf HaChaim and Rabbi Ezra Attiya, and taught the kavanos of the Rashash (Wikipedia). Rabbi Ovadia Yosef was born in Baghdad in 1920 and brought to Jerusalem as a

Aram: Aleppo and Damascus

Aleppo is Aram Tzova and Damascus is Aram Dammesek: the land of Lavan and Bilam. For some six hundred years Aleppo's great synagogue guarded the **Keter Aram Tzova**, the codex of Tanach that the Rambam relied on, until the riots of 1947.[53] Out of Aleppo came **Rabbi Ezra Attiya** (1885–1970), for forty-five years rosh yeshiva of Porat Yosef in Jerusalem and the teacher of a generation of Sephardi gedolim.[54] And the line of the **Baba Sali** begins in Damascus: the family's patriarch, Rabbi Shmuel Elbaz (Abuchatzeira), lived there and learned with Rabbi Chaim Vital before his descendants settled in Morocco.[55]

Charan and Turkey

Charan, where Avraham lived and where Yaakov found Rachel and Leah, lies in today's Turkey. Under the Ottomans, Turkey became a home of Torah. Rabbi Yosef Karo began the Beis Yosef in Adrianople (Edirne); **Rabbi Yaakov Culi** (1689–1732) began the Me'am Lo'ez in Constantinople, bringing the Torah to Jews who spoke only Ladino;[56] and **Rabbi Chaim Palachi** (1788–1868), chief rabbi of Izmir, wrote more than seventy works.[57]

Persia

Persia is where Esther became queen, and Rav Tzadok says the palace of Achashverosh, for all its corruption, became "a dwelling for Esther's holiness."[58] In modern times the **Jews of Mashhad**, forced to convert in 1839, lived as Muslims in public and kept Shabbos, kashrus and Torah in secret for almost a century, until they could live openly as Jews again.[59]

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small child, where he learned at Porat Yosef under Rabbi Ezra Attiya (Aish).

[53]The codex was written in Tiberias around 920 and vocalized by Aharon ben Asher. The Rambam used it as his authority for the writing of a Sefer Torah. It reached Aleppo by about 1375 and was kept in the Central Synagogue for some five to six centuries; after the synagogue was burned in 1947 it was hidden, and it reached Jerusalem in 1958, missing many pages (Wikipedia: Aleppo Codex).

[54]Born in Aleppo in 1885; mashgiach of Porat Yosef when it opened in 1923 and rosh yeshiva from 1925 until his death in 1970 (Wikipedia: Ezra Attiya). Among his students were Rabbi Yehuda Tzadka, Rabbi Yitzchak Kaduri and Rabbi Ovadia Yosef.

[55]The patriarch of the Abuchatzeira family, Rabbi Shmuel Elbaz, was born in Eretz Yisrael, lived for a time in Damascus and learned Torah with Rabbi Chaim Vital; the Chida called him "a holy man of God." His descendants settled in Rissani, Morocco (Wikipedia: Baba Sali).

[56]Rabbi Yaakov Culi was born in Jerusalem in 1689, moved to Constantinople, published the works of his teacher Rabbi Yehuda Rosanes (Mishneh LaMelech), and then began the Me'am Lo'ez in Ladino; he died in 1732 (NJOP).

[57]Rabbi Chaim Palachi (Izmir 1788–1868), Chacham Bashi of Izmir, author of more than seventy works, among them Lev Chaim, Nishmas Kol Chai and Tochachas Chaim (Wikipedia: Haim Palachi).

[58]Rav Tzadok explains that the outward modesty of the Persians, empty as it was, still gave Esther a place (Likkutei Maamarim, Festivals 16:10):

רַק לְפִי שֶׁמִּתּוֹךְ הַגְּנוּת **only because, out of the disgrace,** וְזֶה עַל כָּל פָּנִים **he merited at least** לִהְיוֹת בֵּיתוֹ מָעוֹן **that his palace serve as a dwelling** ,לִקְדוּשַׁת אֶסְתֵּר **for Esther's holiness,** .וְנַעֲשֵׂית לְמַלְכַּת פָּרַס **and she was made Queen of Persia.**

[59]In March 1839 a mob attacked the Jewish quarter of Mashhad and the survivors were forced to declare Islam. For almost a century they went to the mosque in public while keeping Shabbos, kashrus and prayer at home; women hid sifrei Torah

The lands of Yishmael: Yemen, Morocco and the Chida

Pri Tzaddik's "many daughters" include the other lands of exile, and the Gemara counts Torah scholars "from the rising of the sun to its setting" (Menachos 110a). From Yemen, at the southern end of the Arabian desert, came **Rabbi Shalom Sharabi, the Rashash** (1720–1777), who passed through India, Baghdad and Damascus on his way to Jerusalem and became the head of the Beis El kabbalists. Baghdad's kabbalists, Rabbi Fatiyah and Rabbi Kaduri among them, prayed with his kavanos.[60] From Morocco, at the far western edge of Yishmael's lands, came the **Baba Sali**, Rabbi Yisrael Abuchatzeira (1889–1984), grandson of the Abir Yaakov.[61] And the **Chida**, Rabbi Chaim Yosef David Azulai (1724–1806), born in Jerusalem to a family from Morocco, traveled as an emissary through Egypt, Tunisia and Morocco as well as Europe, and wrote some seventy works.[62]

> Strictly, only the first group comes from the lands of the Bnei Kedem: Bavel, Aram, Charan and Persia. Morocco is the far west, and the Chida was born in Eretz Yisrael. They belong to the second family of this shiur, Yishmael, whose kelipah Pri Tzaddik says "can be refined into holiness" (Part VIII), and to the "daughters" of the other lands who "did valiantly."

Hidden souls in Yishmael's house: stories from our time

> Stories are told in our own generation of Jewish souls hidden inside Arab families who found their way back. They are stories, not documented history, and they are brought here as they are told, with their sources.

Rav Yitzchak Zilberstein tells, in **Aleinu Leshabe'ach**, of a young man raised as a Muslim in an Arab village in the Galilee. After a Yom Kippur in a shul in Kiryat Shemona he spoke to his mother, and she told him: "You are a Jew." She came from a family rooted in Tzfas. He began to put on tefillin and came to a talmid chacham in Bnei Brak for Shabbos. Every time **Lecha Dodi** was sung, his eyes filled with tears, and he asked for it again and again. He showed his host an old photograph of his mother's relatives praying at a grave in Tzfas. The next morning the host found the grave: it was the tomb of Rabbi Shlomo Alkabetz, who wrote Lecha Dodi.[63]

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and tefillin, and Rabbi Mordechai Akalar taught the children in secret. They could live openly as Jews from 1925 (Aish: The Secret Jews of Mashhad).

[60]Rabbi Shalom Sharabi was born in 1720 in Sharab, Yemen, and died in Jerusalem in 1777. He became rosh yeshiva of the Beis El kabbalists, and his Siddur HaKavanos is still used by kabbalists in prayer and study (Wikipedia: Shalom Sharabi).

[61]Born in Rissani, Morocco, in 1889, the grandson of Rabbi Yaakov Abuchatzeira (the Abir Yaakov); he moved to Eretz Yisrael in 1951, returned for a time to lead the community in Morocco, settled in Netivot in 1964, and died there in 1984 (Wikipedia: Baba Sali).

[62]Born in Jerusalem in 1724, the great-great-grandson of the Moroccan kabbalist Rabbi Avraham Azulai. As an emissary of Chevron and Eretz Yisrael he traveled to Egypt, Tunisia, Morocco, Italy, Germany, France, Holland and England; he settled in Livorno, where he died in 1806. He wrote about seventy works, including Shem HaGedolim and Birkei Yosef (Wikipedia: Chaim Yosef David Azulai).

[63]The story appears in at least three versions, which agree on the core (a young man raised as a Muslim, a Jewish mother, tears at Lecha Dodi, and a link to Rabbi Shlomo Alkabetz) but differ in the details:

1. Rav Yitzchak Zilberstein, Aleinu Leshabe'ach, as told to him by a talmid chacham in Bnei Brak (the version above; retold in Shema Yisrael, Parshas Shelach). The young man is called Giaber Abu Chusein; his mother says his father was

לְכָה דוֹדִי · Lecha Dodi (Rabbi Shlomo Alkabetz)

Shake off the dust, arise; לְבְשִׁי בִגְדֵי תִפְאַרְתֵּךְ עַמִּי; **put on your garments of glory, my people;** הִתְנַעֲרִי מֵעָפָר קוּמִי, **through the son of Yishai** עַל יַד בֶּן יִשַׁי **of Beis Lechem,** בֵּית הַלַּחְמִי, קָרְבָה אֶל **draw near to my soul and redeem it.** נַפְשִׁי גְּאָלָהּ.

> Rav Tzadok explains how a Jewish soul can be born inside the house of an enemy and still return. He writes it about the descendants of Haman who taught Torah, but the rule is general.

לִקּוּטֵי מַאֲמָרִים, חֲדָשִׁים וּמוֹעֲדִים ט״ז · Likkutei Maamarim, Festivals 16:10

Shaul's compassion [on Agag] וְרַחֲמָנוּת שָׁאוּל **did not come from evil,** לֹא הָיָה עַל דֶּרֶךְ רַע, חַס **Heaven forbid;** וְשָׁלוֹם; **rather he sensed in him** רַק הִרְגִּישׁ בּוֹ **something good,** אֵיזֶה דָּבָר טוֹב, כְּמוֹ **as our Sages said** שֶׁאָמְרוּ זִכְרוֹנָם לִבְרָכָה **(Sanhedrin 96b):** (סַנְהֶדְרִין צו:) **that descendants of Haman** דִּמְבְּנֵי בָּנָיו שֶׁל הָמָן **taught Torah publicly in Bnei Brak…** לָמְדוּ תוֹרָה בָּרַבִּים בִּבְנֵי בְרָק... וּכְבָר **And I have explained elsewhere** בֵּיאַרְתִּי בָּמָקוֹם אַחֵר **that in my view it is clear** דְּהָיָה דִּלְדַעְתִּי בָּרוּר **that this came about through** זֶה עַל יְדֵי בִּיאַת **a man of the seed of Amalek** אֶחָד מִזֶּרַע עֲמָלֵק **with a daughter of Israel;** יִשְׂרָאֵל; **for converts are not accepted from Amalek…;** דַּהֲרֵי אֵין מְקַבְּלִין גֵּרִים מֵעֲמָלֵק... **rather it happened this way:** רַק הָיָה בְּכִהַאי גַּוְונָא: **through a Jewish captive** עַל יְדֵי שְׁבוּיָה **taken among them,** שֶׁנִּשְׁבֵּית בֵּינֵיהֶם, **or some other case of force;** אוֹ בְּעִנְיָן אַחֵר בְּאוֹנֶס; **and the halachah is (Yevamos 45a)** וְקַיְימָא לָן (יְבָמוֹת מה.) **that the child is a kosher Jew…** דְּהַוָּלָד כָּשֵׁר... **And in this way** וּבְעִנְיָן זֶה ... **there is an absorbing, even from Amalek,** יֵשׁ קְלִיטָה גַּם מֵעֲמָלֵק **into holiness;** בִּקְדוּשָׁה; **for certainly, Heaven forbid** דְּוַדַּאי, חַס וְשָׁלוֹם, **to blot out that holy seed,** לִמְחוֹת אוֹתוֹ הַזֶּרַע קָדוֹשׁ, **who is a kosher Israelite.** שֶׁהוּא יִשְׂרָאֵל כָּשֵׁר. **the son of a Jewish woman,** בֶּן הַיִּשְׂרְאֵלִית,

Two more stories of the same kind have been reported in our time. **Mark Halawa** was born in Kuwait to a Palestinian Muslim family. He grew up knowing that his mother's mother had been a Jew in Jerusalem, without knowing what it meant, until a Jewish professor in Canada told him that it made him Jewish. He moved to Jerusalem, learned in yeshiva, married, and lives there as an observant Jew.[64] And a young man in Jordan, called "**Ahmed**" in the report, whose mother and grandmother were Jews from Iraq, from Bavel, learned by chance from a video of the religious singer Ziv Yechezkel that Jewishness passes

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Druze; he worked in Kiryat Shemona.

2. Zev Roth, Monsey, Kiryat Sefer, and Beyond (Targum Press, 2002), "Coming Home from Ramallah" (Breslev Israel). Here he is "Machmud" from Ramallah, hosted in Jerusalem; his mother gives him her old Israeli identity card and the photograph from the grave. Roth writes: "The story is true; the names have been changed."

3. Oded Mizrahi, "Yehudi BeDam" (abc770). Here "Mahmoud" from a Galilee village later takes the name Yehuda Alkabetz; he first sees Lecha Dodi in a siddur on Yom Kippur, learns in Bayit Vegan, and is married with the help of Rav Ovadia Yosef. His aunt's family tradition is that they descend from "a great rabbi buried in Tzfas."

None of the versions gives a date or details that can be checked, and the names differ. The descent from Rabbi Shlomo Alkabetz is the weakest part: a photograph of relatives praying at a tzaddik's grave shows that they visited it, and many people pray there. What matters for halachah, and for this shiur, is the Jewish mother.

[64]Deborah Danan, "An Arab Comes Home to His Judaism," Jewish Journal, March 28, 2018 (Jewish Journal). He learned at the University of Western Ontario that his maternal grandmother's Jewishness made him Jewish, and later made Arabic-language videos explaining Israel to the Arab world.

through the mother. He contacted Yad L'Achim, which sends him books on Judaism in Arabic, and he keeps his Judaism secret for fear of those around him. The organization said it had received similar requests from some 150 people across the Muslim world in a year and a half.[65]

> In every one of these stories the way back runs through a Jewish mother, exactly as Rav Tzadok explains: the son of a Jewish woman is "a kosher Israelite," a holy seed that cannot be blotted out. And in each one something small of Torah stayed alive inside Yishmael's house, a song of Shabbos, a grandmother's name, a Chanukah light, until the soul recognized it. Memories of Jewish customs kept by families whose Jewish ancestry ran only through the fathers, centuries back, have not brought them back in the same way.

Summing Up

> The two families sent from Avraham's house were not lost to it. Keturah's sons carried a Name, and with it the hidden sparks of the Oral Torah, into the East; Shlomo's wisdom grew by drawing those sparks back. Yishmael carried the wisdom of nature; he fell because he trusted it alone, and he returned in Avraham's lifetime because Avraham's root in him would not let him stay. In both cases the husk came first and the fruit came later, through Yitzchak and through Yaakov.
>
> That is the "great increase" of the end. There is no light like the light that comes out of darkness, and the Oral Torah that Israel draws out of the East is the "tov me'od" of Shabbos. We read this parsha on Shabbos, the time Pri Tzaddik names for receiving that Oral Torah.
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> And the story did not end with Tanach. The exile returned Israel to Avraham's East and spread it through Yishmael's lands, and out of Bavel, Aram, Charan, Persia and the West came the Talmud Bavli, the Ben Ish Chai, the Kaf HaChaim, the Rashash, Rabbi Ezra Attiya, Rabbi Ovadia Yosef, the Baba Sali and the Chida. "In proportion to the intensity of the darkness, so does it shine brighter" (Poked Akarim).

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[65] World Israel News, July 31, 2019, citing Ma'ariv (World Israel News). The account comes from Yad L'Achim and from Ahmed's interview; it was not independently checked. In the same year Israel Hayom reported a man from a family of hidden Jews in an Arab country with no ties to Israel who lit Chanukah candles in secret (Israel Hayom, December 27, 2019).

For contrast: in 1928 Yitzchak Ben-Zvi, later Israel's second president, recorded that the Makhamra clan of Yatta, near Chevron, said "We the Makhamra are from the seed of Jews" and avoided camel meat (She'ar Yeshuv); a 1938 report in the Palestine Post described families in Yatta lighting Chanukah candles obtained from the Jews of Chevron. Their tradition traces Jewish descent through the fathers, many generations back, and its origin is disputed; they have remained Muslims (Wikipedia: Makhamra family).

Sources in This Shiur

Every passage quoted above, with a link to it in the Kisvei Rav Tzadok reader.

Source	Where in the shiur
Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 6	I–IV, IX
Pri Tzaddik, Chayei Sarah 8	VIII
Pri Tzaddik, Mishpatim 4	VIII
Mei HaShiloach I, Chayei Sarah 5	V
Mei HaShiloach I, Ki Seitzei 8	note to I
Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 33	note to II
Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 36	II
Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 37	V
Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 39	VII
Beis Yaakov, Chayei Sarah 40	VI
Beis Yaakov, Toldos 7	VII
Yisrael Kedoshim 10:26	IX (note)
Kometz HaMinchah 2:59	VII; notes to I and V
Divrei Soferim 38	VIII
Takanas HaShavin 15:45	note to VIII
Tzidkas HaTzaddik 249	note to III
Likkutei Maamarim, Upon Completion of the Talmud 5	note to III
Likkutei Maamarim, On the Book of Joshua 5	note to III
Pri Tzaddik, Tazria 8	X
Pri Tzaddik, Yisro 1	X
Poked Akarim 6:4	X
Resisei Layla 46:2	X
Divrei Soferim 38:13	note to X
Likkutei Maamarim, Festivals 16:10	X

Supporting Sources from Other Seforim

Sources outside the Kisvei Rav Tzadok library that are quoted in the footnotes, with links to Sefaria.

Source	Kind	Part
Zohar, Vayera (Rabbi Abba and the book of the East)	Kabbalah	III
Zohar Chadash, Yisro	Kabbalah	VIII

Source	Kind	Part
Recanati on the Torah, Chayei Sarah	Kabbalah	II
Shelah, Chayei Sarah, Torah Ohr 15	Kabbalah and mussar	II
Shelah, Toldos, Torah Ohr 49	Kabbalah and mussar	VII
Maharal, Gur Aryeh, Bereishis 25:6	Machshavah	II
Maharal, Netiv HaTorah 14	Machshavah	V
Ramban, Shemos 13:16	Machshavah	V
Malbim, Bereishis 25:1	Machshavah	VII
Da'as Zekenim, Bereishis 25:6	Rishonim	II
Rashi, I Melachim 5:10	Rishonim	III
Radak, I Melachim 5:10	Rishonim	III
Taz, Orach Chaim 224:1	Halachah and machshavah	V
Me'or Einayim, Noach	Chassidus	III
Kedushas Levi, Bereishis	Chassidus	IX
Tanya, ch. 27	Chassidus	IX
Arvei Nachal, Chayei Sarah	Chassidus	VIII
Shem MiShmuel, Shemos	Chassidus	VIII
Mesillas Yesharim, ch. 1	Mussar	VI
Avos 3:9	Mishnah	VI
Eichah Rabbah 2:13	Midrash	V
Pesachim 87b; Pesachim 56a	Gemara	III, VIII
Berachos 26b; Mishnah Berachos 5:1	Gemara and Mishnah	IX
Bnei Kedem in Tanach: Bereishis 29:1, Bamidbar 23:7, Iyov 1:3, Shoftim 6:3, Yirmiyahu 49:28	Tanach	II
Lavan and Bilam: Bereishis 30:27; Bamidbar 22:7, 24:16	Tanach	III
Mishlei 25:4 (dross)	Tanach	VIII
Aish: Abraham's Impure Gifts (Rav Pinchas Winston; R' Dov Ber Cohen)	Contemporary	III
Lubavitcher Rebbe on meditation, 5738–5739 (Kavvanah blog)	Contemporary	II
Rabbi Aryeh Kaplan, Jewish Meditation	Contemporary	IX
Pesachim 87b, with Rashi	Gemara	X
Sanhedrin 24a	Gemara	X

Source	Kind	Part
Menachos 110a	Gemara	X
Bava Basra 15a (Eisan HaEzrachi)	Gemara	X
Ben Ish Chai; Kaf HaChaim; R’ Yehuda Fatiyah	History	X
R’ Salman Mutzafi; R’ Yitzchak Kaduri; R’ Ovadia Yosef	History	X
Aleppo Codex; R’ Ezra Attiya	History	X
R’ Yaakov Culi; R’ Chaim Palachi	History	X
The Jews of Mashhad	History	X
The Rashash; the Baba Sali; the Chida	History	X
The Lecha Dodi story (R’ Zilberstein, Aleinu Leshabe’ach; Z. Roth; O. Mizrahi)	Story	X
Mark Halawa (Jewish Journal, 2018)	Story	X
“Ahmed” of Jordan (World Israel News, 2019)	Story	X
The Makhamra clan of Yatta (Ben-Zvi)	History	X (note)